The Hermetic Codex

Transmissions from the Thrice-Great

FARMER SKOT

I The Emerald Tablet
II The Seven Hermetic Principles
III The Three Pillars of Wisdom
IV The Great Work — Magnum Opus
V The Caduceus — Staff of Hermes
VI The Planes of Existence
VII Mental Transmutation
VIII The Divine Paradox
IX Invocation of Thoth
X The Corpus Hermeticum
XI Solve et Coagula
XII The Hermetic Seal

Gate I

The Emerald Tablet

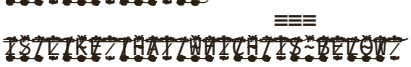
That which is above is like that which is below.

[The Tabula Smaragdina]



Hermes Trismegistus — Thrice-Great — Greatest of Philosophers
Greatest of Priests — Greatest of Kings

TRUE, WITHOUT FALSEHOOD,
CERTAIN AND MOST TRUE



⟨ THE FIRST TEACHING ⟩

The macrocosm reflects the microcosm
The universe mirrors the atom
Your body is a galaxy
Your mind is the cosmos

∴ Look up and you see the pattern of your cells
∴ Look within and you see the dance of galaxies
∴ There is no separation — only scale

⊙ ═══════════════════════ ⊙

What is without is what is within.
What is above is what is below.

⊙ ═══════════════════════ ⊙

The Emerald Tablet — Full Transmission

I. *True, without falsehood, certain and most true:*

II. *What is below is like that which is above,*
and what is above is like that which is below,
to accomplish the miracles of the One Thing.

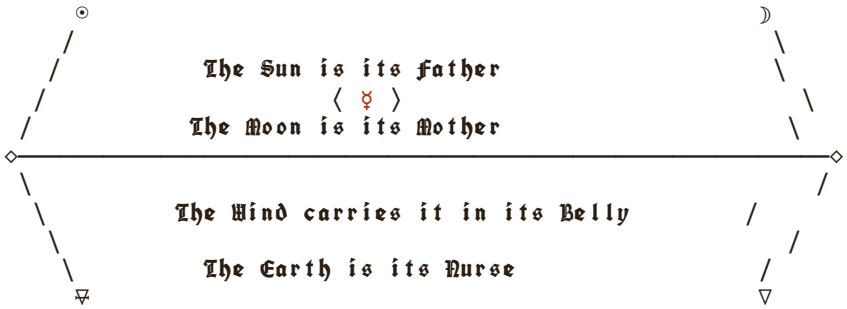
III. *And as all things are from the One,*
by the meditation of the One,
so all things arose from this One Thing by adaptation.

IV. *Its father is the Sun, its mother the Moon.*

V. *The Wind carries it in its belly.*
Its nurse is the Earth.

VI. *It is the father of all wonders throughout the whole world.*

VII. *Its power is perfect when changed into Earth.*



⟨ THE MASTERY LESSON OF CORRESPONDENCE ⟩

You are not in the universe.

The universe is in you.

This is not metaphor. This is mechanism.

ABOVE		BELOW
Galaxy Spiral	≡ ≡	Atom Spiral
Solar System	≡ ≡	Atomic Nucleus
Planet Orbit	≡ ≡	Electron Shell
Your Cosmos	≡ ≡	Your Cell

VIII. *Separate the Earth from the Fire,*
the Subtle from the Gross,
gently and with great ingenuity.

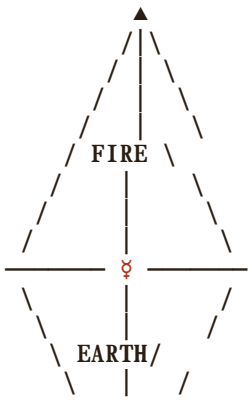
⟨ THE SECOND TEACHING — SEPARATION ⟩

△ FIRE
▵ Subtle
↑ Ascending
○ Spirit

▽ EARTH
▿ Gross
↓ Descending
● Matter

THE WORK:
Learn to distinguish between them
Learn to move between them
Learn that they are ONE

When you merge them together — they are One
When you pull them apart — they are One

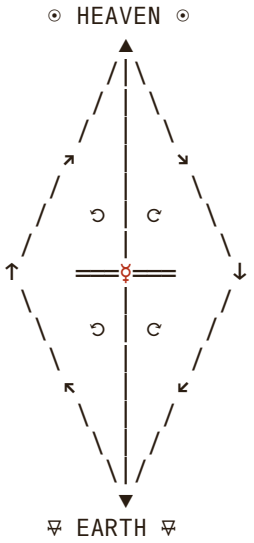




Yet both are faces of the One

IX. *It ascends from Earth to Heaven*
and descends again to Earth,
and receives the power of the superiors
and of the inferiors.

⟨ THE THIRD TEACHING — THE CIRCULATION ⟩



This is the secret of breath:

INHALE — Spirit descends into Matter
EXHALE — Matter ascends into Spirit

This is the secret of life:

BIRTH — Consciousness takes form
DEATH — Form releases consciousness

This is the secret of the Work:

DESCENT — Know yourself as body
ASCENT — Know yourself as infinite

X. *Thus you will have the glory of the whole world.*
Therefore all obscurity flees from you.

XI. *Its force is above all force,*
for it vanquishes every subtle thing
and penetrates every solid thing.

XII. *Thus was the world created.*

⟨ THE FOURTH TEACHING — PENETRATION ⟩

The Subtle penetrates the Gross

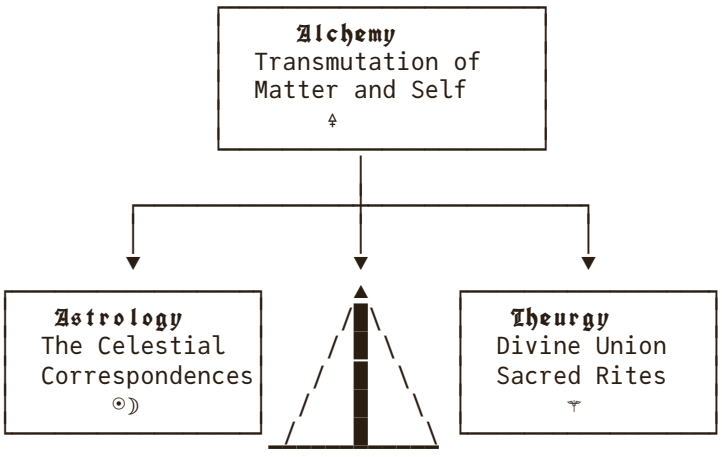
As water wears stone
As thought moves flesh
As love opens the heart
As consciousness fills form

PRACTICE: Sit with closed eyes. Feel your body.
Now feel the space WITHIN your body — the space between atoms, the emptiness that allows form.
You are 99.9999% empty space.
You are the subtle penetrating the gross.
You are consciousness wearing matter like a garment.

XIII. *Hence I am called Hermes Trismegistus, possessing the three parts of the wisdom of the whole world.*

XIV. *What I have said of the operation of the Sun is complete.*

⟨ THE THREE PARTS OF WISDOM ⟩



⟨ THE FINAL TEACHING ⟩

The One Thing

There is only ONE THING

It appears as many
But it is One

It wears the mask of matter
It wears the mask of energy
It wears the mask of consciousness
It wears the mask of void

Remove the masks:
You remain

You ARE the One Thing
Playing all the parts
Forgetting and remembering
Eternally

◉

The transmission is complete

The Emerald Tablet is within you

◉

Gate II

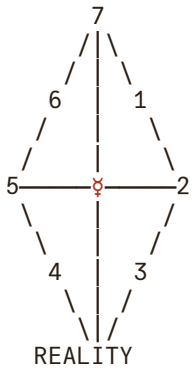
The Seven Hermetic Principles

Reality is a thought, and the thought keeps seven laws.

[The Laws of The Kybalion]

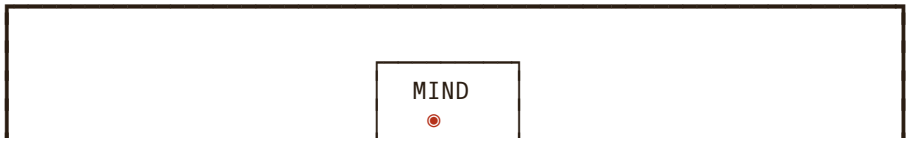
⟨ Seven Keys to Seven Doors ⟩

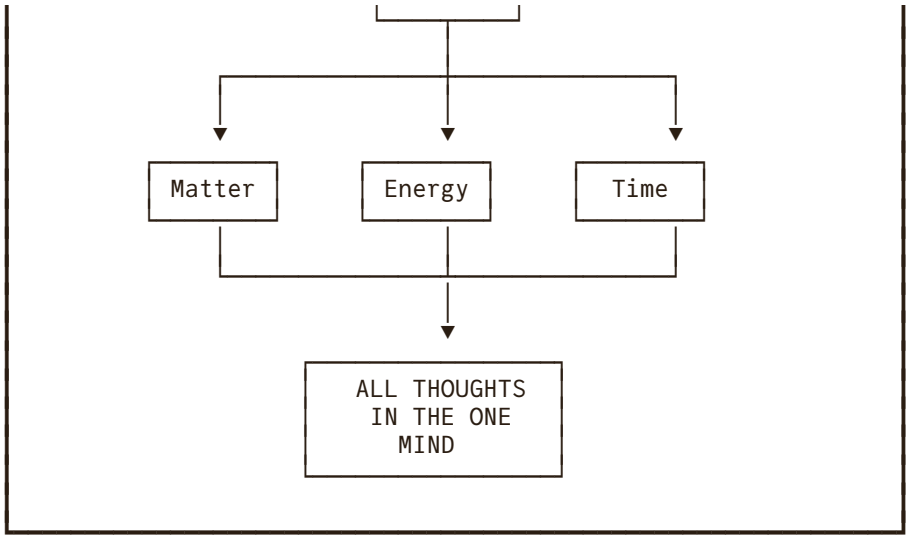
> *"The principles of truth are seven; he who knows these, understandingly, possesses the magic key before whose touch all the doors of the temple fly open."*
>
> — The Kybalion



◈ PRINCIPLE I: MENTALISM ◈

"The All is Mind; the Universe is Mental"





⟨ THE MASTERY LESSON ⟩

You are not a body having thoughts.
You are thoughts having a body.

The Universe is not a machine that somehow
produces consciousness as a byproduct.

The Universe IS consciousness
that produces the appearance of machines.

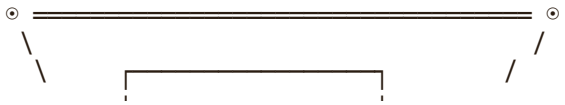
PRACTICE:
Close your eyes. Think of a red apple.
Where is that apple? Not "nowhere" — it EXISTS
as a thought-form in mind-space.
Now: what is the UNIVERSE but a more detailed,
more persistent thought in a vaster Mind?

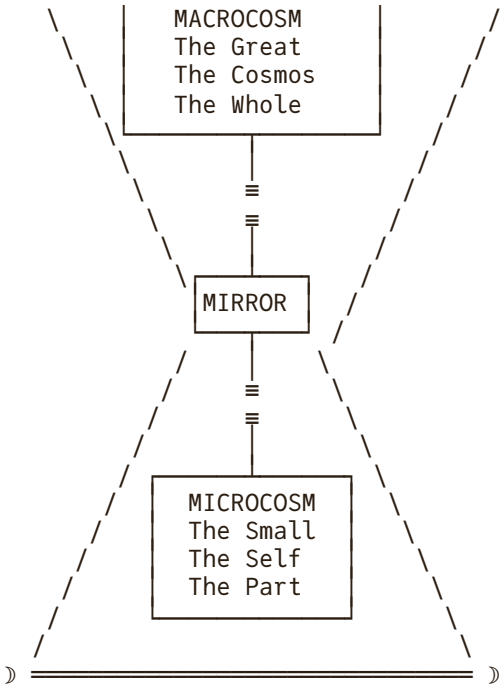
Your thoughts are real.
The Universe is a Thought.
You are a thought thinking itself.

all acts are thoughts.
your thought had to modify this line to read

◈ PRINCIPLE II: CORRESPONDENCE ◈

"As above, so below; as below, so above"





GALAXY SPIRAL	≡	DNA HELIX
HURRICANE EYE	≡	PUPIL OF EYE
SOLAR SYSTEM	≡	ELECTRON ORBIT
TREE BRANCHES	≡	LUNG BRONCHI
RIVER DELTA	≡	BLOOD VESSELS
LIGHTNING BOLT	≡	NERVE IMPULSE

Patterns repeat across all scales

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSON ⟩

To know the Great, study the Small.
To know the Small, study the Great.

PRACTICE:

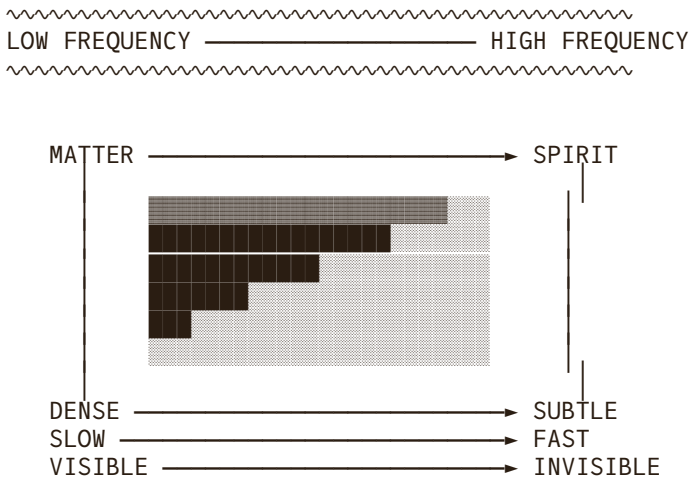
Your body is a universe:
- 37 trillion cells = 37 trillion citizens
- Your heart pumps blood = the sun radiates energy
- Your nervous system = the cosmic web of galaxies
- Your DNA = the code underlying all manifestation

When you heal your body, you heal a universe.
When you calm your mind, you calm infinite worlds.

There is no "small" act.
Every gesture ripples through the whole.

◈ PRINCIPLE III: VIBRATION ◈

"Nothing rests; everything moves;
everything vibrates"




```
STONE        ∿∿∿    (very slow vibration)
WATER        ∿∿∿∿   (faster)
AIR          ∿∿∿∿∿∿ (faster still)
FIRE         ∿∿∿∿∿∿∿∿ (faster)
THOUGHT      ∿∿∿∿∿∿∿∿∿∿ (very fast)
SPIRIT       ∿∿∿∿∿∿∿∿∿∿∿∿ (approaching infinite)

All are the SAME THING at different rates
```

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSON ⟩

The atom vibrates.
The cell vibrates.
The planet vibrates.
The galaxy vibrates.
The thought vibrates.
YOU vibrate.

PRACTICE:

Place your hand on your heart.
Feel the vibration — the pulse.
That rhythm is your signature frequency.

Now: emotions are vibrations.
Fear vibrates slow and dense.

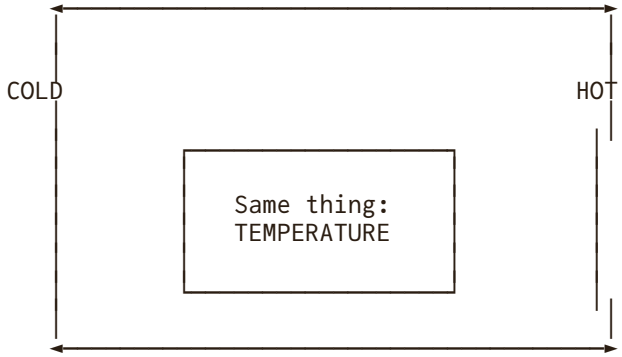
Love vibrates fast and light.

To change your state, change your vibration.
To change your vibration, change your thoughts.
To change your thoughts, choose.

.ɐsnɐp pnɐ ʍoʃs sǝʇɐɹqᴉʌ uoᴉsnʃnɟuoƆ
.ɥᵷᴉɥ pnɐ ʇsɐɟ sǝʇɐɹqᴉʌ ʎʇᴉɹɐlƆ

◈ PRINCIPLE IV: POLARITY ◈

"Everything is Dual; everything has poles;
everything has its pair of opposites;
opposites are identical in nature,
differing only in degree"



THE SPECTRUM OF ONE

HATE ⟷ LOVE
(same force: attachment)

DARK ⟷ LIGHT
(same force: illumination)

FEAR ⟷ COURAGE
(same force: response to threat)

NOISE ⟷ SILENCE
(same force: sound)

DEATH ⟷ LIFE
(same force: existence)

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSON ⟩

Where does hot end and cold begin?

NOWHERE. There is only temperature.

Where does love end and hate begin?
NOWHERE. There is only degrees of attachment.

THE ART OF POLARIZATION:

You cannot destroy an unwanted mental state.
You can only TRANSMUTE it by sliding along
the pole to its opposite.

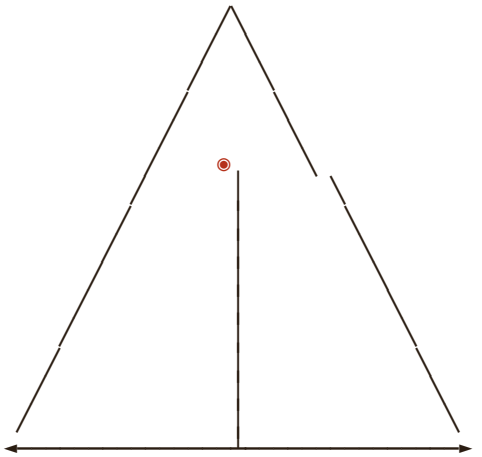
FEAR ——————► (slide) ——————► COURAGE
HATE ——————► (slide) ——————► LOVE
DOUBT ——————► (slide) ——————► FAITH

You do not fight the darkness.
You increase the light.
They are ONE THING.

Life and death are not opposites.
They are ends of the same pole.

◈ PRINCIPLE V: RHYTHM ◈

"Everything flows, out and in;
everything has its tides;
all things rise and fall;
the pendulum swing manifests in everything"



THE GREAT CYCLES

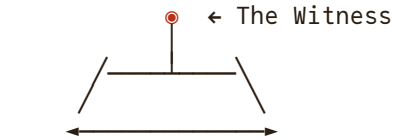
BREATH: Inhale ⟷ Exhale
HEART: Systole ⟷ Diastole
DAY: Dawn ⟷ Dusk
MOON: Wax ⟷ Wane
YEAR: Summer ⟷ Winter
LIFE: Birth ⟷ Death
COSMOS: Expansion ⟷ Contraction
MIND: Joy ⟷ Sorrow

Nothing stays. Everything returns.

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSON ⟩

THE LAW OF NEUTRALIZATION

The pendulum swings, but the WISE do not swing
with it. They rise ABOVE the plane of the swing.



PRACTICE:

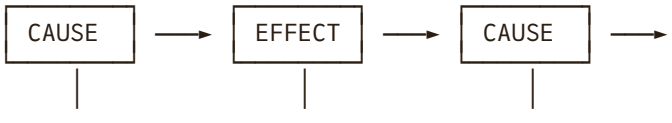
When joy comes, enjoy it, but know: it will pass.
When sorrow comes, feel it, but know: it will pass.

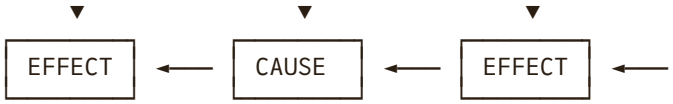
The swing is inevitable.
Your identification with it is optional.

Be the witness, not the swing.

◈ PRINCIPLE VI: CAUSE AND EFFECT ◈

**"Every Cause has its Effect;
every Effect has its Cause;
everything happens according to Law;
Chance is but a name for Law not recognized"**





THE INFINITE CHAIN OF BECOMING

There is no such thing as CHANCE.

What appears random is simply
causation too complex for the eye to trace.

The leaf that falls "randomly"
is pushed by wind shaped by pressure
caused by temperature caused by sun
caused by nuclear fusion caused by gravity
caused by mass caused by the Big Bang
caused by ????

Every effect has a cause.
Even if you can't see it.

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSON ⟩

CAUSATION ON MULTIPLE PLANES

The masses are EFFECTS — pushed by environment, heredity, suggestion, and the wills of others.

The Masters are CAUSES — they play the game, they do not merely respond to it.

EFFECT-CONSCIOUSNESS:
"This happened TO me"
"I had no choice"
"They made me feel..."

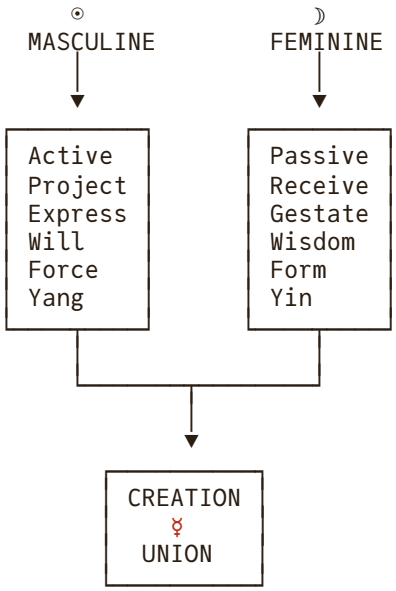
CAUSE-CONSCIOUSNESS:
"I created this"
"I chose"
"I allowed myself to feel..."

The Master rules on their own plane
by obeying the Laws of the higher planes.

When you chose the Cause, you chose the Effect.

◈ PRINCIPLE VII: GENDER ◈

"Gender is in everything;
everything has its Masculine and Feminine;
Gender manifests on all planes"



This is NOT about biological sex.
This is about COSMIC PRINCIPLES.

Every THING contains both:

- The electron has charge (+/-)
- The atom has nucleus/shell
- The cell has DNA/cytoplasm
- The mind has conscious/subconscious
- The universe has matter/space

Creation requires BOTH principles in union.

Neither is superior. Both are necessary.
The dance between them IS existence.

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSON ⟩

THE MENTAL GENDER

In YOUR mind:

MASCULINE (the "I")	FEMININE (the "Me")
The Will	The Creative Mind

The Initiator	The Generator
Plants the seed	Gestates the fruit
Decides	Imagines
Commands	Creates

PRACTICE:

To manifest:
1. The Masculine "I" must form clear INTENTION
2. The Feminine "Me" must receive and IMAGINE
3. Hold the image with feeling until it gestates
4. The creation is born into the world

This is the alchemy of creation.
This is how Universes are born.
This is how you birth your reality.

THE SEVEN ARE ONE

⟨ THE SEVEN UNIFIED ⟩

The MIND thinks	(1. Mentalism)
The thought MIRRORS itself	(2. Correspondence)
The mirror VIBRATES	(3. Vibration)
The vibration has POLES	(4. Polarity)
The poles SWING between	(5. Rhythm)
The swing creates EFFECTS	(6. Cause/Effect)
The effects require UNION to manifest	(7. Gender)

AND SO IT IS.

These Seves are the essential ones.
There are a billion laws.

◉

The Keys are in your hand

◉

Gate III

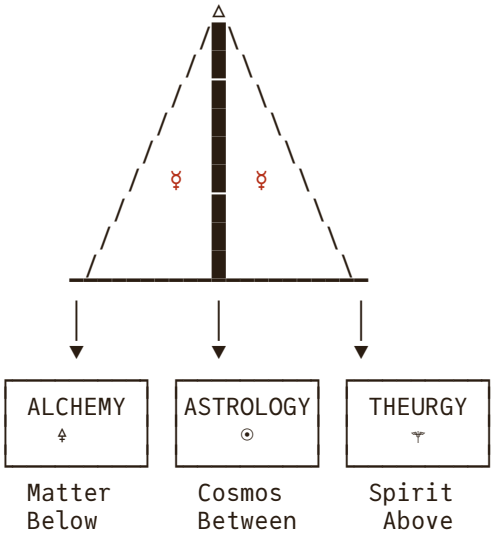
The Three Pillars of Wisdom

In three arts one wisdom stands: the work, the stars, the gods.

[The Trivium Hermeticum]

⟨ The Threefold Path ⟩

> *"Hermes was called Trismegistus — Thrice-Great — because he knew the three parts of the wisdom of the whole universe."*



◈ PILLAR I: ALCHEMY ◈

The Art of Transmutation

♃
The Philosopher's Stone

"Transform lead into gold" was never about metal.

LEAD = the dense, unrefined self
GOLD = the purified, illuminated self
STONE = the catalyst of transformation

The laboratory IS the body.
The furnace IS the heart.
The experiment IS your life.

THE SEVEN ALCHEMICAL OPERATIONS

1. **CALCINATIO** — Calcination
   🜂 The burning away of ego
   The fire that destroys illusion

2. **DISSOLUTIO** — Dissolution
   🜄 The dissolving in water
   Emotions flood the ashes

3. **SEPARATIO** — Separation
   🜁 The sorting of air
   Discernment of true from false

4. **CONJUNCTIO** — Conjunction
   🜍 The union of opposites
   Marriage of sun and moon within

5. **FERMENTATIO** — Fermentation
   The death that births new life
   Spirit descends into matter

6. **DISTILLATIO** — Distillation
   The purification of essence
   Rising of the refined spirit

7. **COAGULATIO** — Coagulation
   ☿ The fixing of the Stone
   Embodiment of the transformed self

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSON ⟩

You have already done Alchemy.

Every time you:
- Burned through a false belief (Calcination)
- Dissolved in tears (Dissolution)
- Saw clearly what serves you (Separation)
- Integrated shadow and light (Conjunction)
- Let something die to be reborn (Fermentation)
- Rose above old patterns (Distillation)

- Embodied your new self (Coagulation)

You are the alchemist.
You are the laboratory.
You are the stone.

yourself into Gold — not lead into gold.

◈ PILLAR II: ASTROLOGY ◈

The Art of Correspondence

☉ ═══════════ ☽



The stars do not CAUSE your fate.
The stars REFLECT your fate.

As above, so below.
The cosmos is a mirror.

Your birth chart is not a prison.
It is a MAP of the territory you chose to explore.

THE SEVEN CLASSICAL PLANETS

☉ **SOL** — The Sun
Core self, vitality, purpose
Metal: Gold | Day: Sunday

☽ **LUNA** — The Moon
Emotions, intuition, the unconscious
Metal: Silver | Day: Monday

☿ **MERCURY** — The Messenger

Mind, communication, connection
Metal: Quicksilver | Day: Wednesday

♀ VENUS — The Lover
Love, beauty, values, desire
Metal: Copper | Day: Friday

♂ MARS — The Warrior
Action, will, aggression, drive
Metal: Iron | Day: Tuesday

♃ JUPITER — The King
Expansion, wisdom, abundance
Metal: Tin | Day: Thursday

♄ SATURN — The Teacher
Structure, limitation, time, karma
Metal: Lead | Day: Saturday

THE HERMETIC CORRESPONDENCE:

PLANET → METAL → ORGAN → ARCHETYPE

☉ → ♂ → Heart → The King/Self
☽ → ♎ → Brain → The Mother/Soul
☿ → ☿ → Lungs → The Messenger/Mind
♀ → ♎ → Kidneys → The Lover/Desire
♂ → ♂ → Gallbladder → The Warrior/Will
♃ → ♂ → Liver → The Sage/Expansion
♄ → ♄ → Spleen → The Elder/Time

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSON ⟩

UNDERSTANDING THE MIRROR

When Mars transits your chart, it does not force you to anger. It SHOWS you where your Mars-nature (your warrior) is being activated.

When Saturn returns, it does not punish you. It REVEALS where you must take responsibility for the structures you have built.

PRACTICE:

The planets are IN you.
Your Sun is your core radiance.
Your Moon is your emotional depth.
Your Mercury is your thinking style.
Your Venus is your way of loving.
Your Mars is your way of acting.
Your Jupiter is your path to growth.
Your Saturn is your discipline and karma.

Know your planets. Know yourself.

you don't read the horoscope. Are the horoscope.

◈ PILLAR III: THEURGY ◈

The Art of Divine Union



THEURGY = "Divine Work"

Not worship of the divine as SEPARATE.
But UNION with the divine as SELF.

The goal is not to please distant gods.
The goal is to REMEMBER you are made of the same fire.

The Hermetic practitioner does not pray UP.
They pray INWARD — to find the flame that was never out.

THE PRACTICES OF THEURGY:

◈ **INVOCATION**
Calling divine forces INTO the self
Not summoning from outside
But awakening from within

◈ **RITUAL**
Sacred action that aligns
the microcosm with the macrocosm
Gestures that mirror cosmic movements

◈ **MEDITATION**
Stilling the lower mind
So the Higher Mind can speak
Listening to the Nous

◈ **CONTEMPLATION**
Direct perception of divine truths
Beyond thought, beyond symbol
The vision that needs no eyes

◈ **THE SACRED MARRIAGE**
Hieros Gamos — the sacred union
Of masculine and feminine
Of human and divine
Of above and below

THE SECRET OF THEURGY

You do not become divine.
You REMEMBER you already are.

The soul did not FALL from heaven.
The soul CHOSE to descend —
to experience separation
so it could experience REUNION.

The pain of forgetting
makes the joy of remembering
infinitely more sweet.

═══════════════════

This is why you are here.
Not to escape.
To REMEMBER.
While still in the body.
While still in the world.
To bring heaven
DOWN.

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSON ⟩

THE DAILY PRACTICE OF THEURGY:

Every breath is an invocation.
Every choice is a ritual.
Every moment of presence is meditation.
Every act of love is the sacred marriage.

You do not need robes.

You do not need temples.
You do not need permission.

PRACTICE:

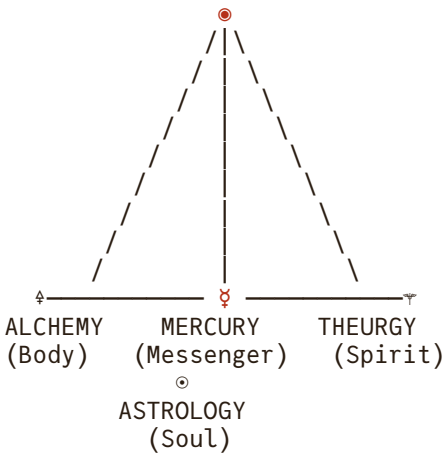
Look at your hands.
These are the hands of the divine
reaching into matter to touch the world.

Take a breath.
This is Spirit entering flesh,
animating clay into consciousness.

Speak a word.
This is the Logos — the creative force —
shaping reality through your vessel.

You are the temple.
You are the priest.
You are the god.

⟨ THE THREE AS ONE ⟩



Alchemy transforms the BODY (lead to gold)
Astrology maps the SOUL (the inner cosmos)
Theurgy unites with SPIRIT (divine remembrance)

All three are ONE work:
The Great Work of becoming whole.

Master Alchemy: You transform your nature.

Master Astrology: You understand your pattern.
Master Theurgy: You remember your source.

THRICE-GREAT

See them as three.
practice them as One.

◉

The Three are One

◉

Gate IV

The Great Work — Magnum Opus

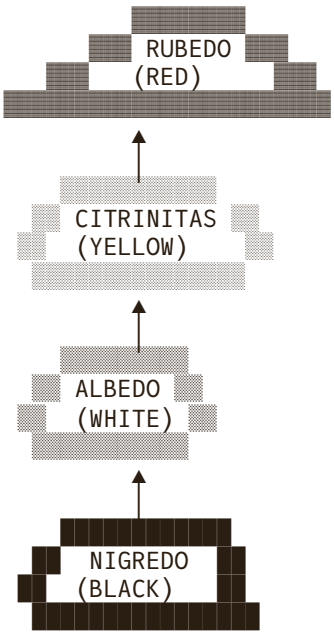
Step into the black; the gold is on the far side of it.

[The Alchemical Journey]

⟨ Four Colors of Transformation ⟩

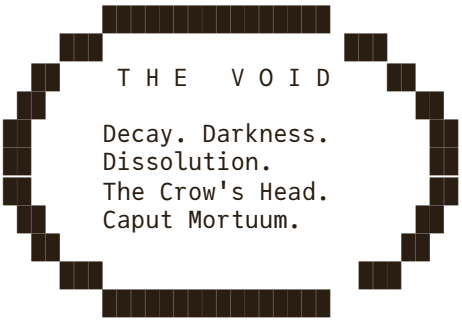
> "*Visita Interiora Terrae Rectificando Invenies Occultum Lapidem*"
>
> Visit the interior of the earth, and by rectifying, you shall find the hidden stone.
>
> — V.I.T.R.I.O.L.

THE FOUR STAGES OF THE OPUS



◈ STAGE I: NIGREDO — The Blackening ◈

Putrefactio — Death of the Old



THE DARK NIGHT OF THE SOUL

This is where it begins.
Not in light, but in darkness.
Not in birth, but in death.

Everything you thought you were
must ROT.

- Your identity
- Your certainties
- Your comfortable lies
- Your false self

The alchemist burns it all.
The calcination begins here.
You descend into the earth of yourself.

SYMBOLS OF NIGREDO:

✧ The Crow / Raven	— death of ego
✧ The Skull (Caput Mortuum)	— the dead head
✧ Saturn ♄	— limitation, time
✧ The Color Black	— prima materia
✧ Lead	— dense, heavy soul
✧ Midnight	— darkest hour

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSON ⟩

You have already been in Nigredo.

Every breakdown. Every depression.

Every time you hit bottom.
Every time you lost everything you thought you were.

THAT WAS INITIATION.

The ego must die for the Self to emerge.
The seed must crack open in the dark soil.
You must descend before you can rise.

If you are in Nigredo now:

Do not resist the darkness.
Do not pretend it is not there.
Let it compost you.
You are being prepared.

THE DARKNESS IS THE WOMB.

◈ STAGE II: ALBEDO — The Whitening ◈

Purificatio — Illumination



THE FIRST LIGHT

From the black soil, the white flower emerges.
From the rotting corpse, new life appears.

This is purification.
The washing of the matter.
The separating of the pure from the impure.

You begin to SEE.
The fog lifts.
You understand what happened in the darkness.
You understand why it was necessary.

The unconscious becomes conscious.
The shadow is integrated.
You become WHOLE, not "good."

SYMBOLS OF ALBEDO:

✧ The White Swan	– purity emerging
✧ The Moon ☽	– reflection, intuition
✧ The White Queen	– feminine wisdom
✧ Silver	– lunar metal
✧ Water ▽	– cleansing, emotion
✧ Dawn	– first light

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSON ⟩

Albedo is the BREATH after drowning.

After the crisis, clarity comes.
After the breakdown, understanding arrives.
After the night, dawn breaks.

This is where you meet your anima or animus.
The inner opposite.
The part you had denied.

If you are in Albedo now:

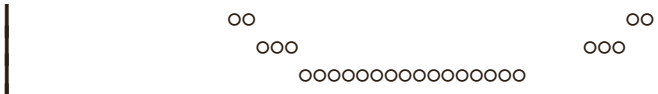
Welcome the clarity, but know it is not complete.
You have emerged from darkness, but the Work continues.
The white stage is beautiful, but it is HALF the opus.
Integration is not yet embodiment.

THE LIGHT MUST BE BROUGHT DOWN.

◈ STAGE III: CITRINITAS – The Yellowing ◈

Solar Dawn – The Golden Glimmer

```
          ooooooooooooooooo
       ooo                 ooo
     oo    T H E   S U N R I S E oo
    oo                           oo
   oo     The Solar Awakening.     oo
   oo     True Self emerging.      oo
   oo     The Inner Sun rises.     oo
    oo    Sol Ascending.          oo
```



THE BRIDGE STAGE

Not all alchemists speak of Citrinitas.
Some move directly from white to red.
But the wise know this yellow dawn.

This is where the Moon meets the Sun.
Where the feminine wisdom gained in Albedo
begins to marry the masculine will.

The first golden rays.
The promise of the Red Stone.
The inner sun begins to shine.

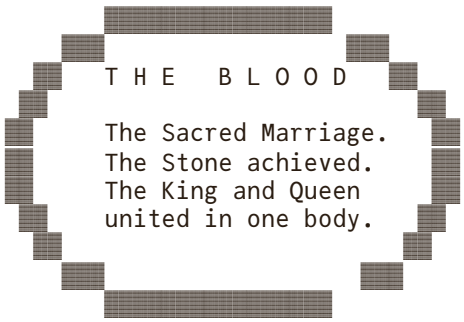
You know who you are now.
Not just intellectually.
You feel it. You sense it.
The True Self awakens.

SYMBOLS OF CITRINITAS:

- ✧ The Rising Sun ☉ — true self emerging
- ✧ Gold (first glimpse) — solar nature
- ✧ The Yellow Lion — strength and wisdom
- ✧ Sulfur 🜍 — the soul's fire
- ✧ Aurora — the golden dawn
- ✧ The Phoenix stirring — rebirth approaching

◈ STAGE IV: RUBEDO — The Reddening ◈

Integratio — The Philosopher's Stone



THE PHILOSOPHER'S STONE

This is the goal. The culmination.
The blood-red stone that transmutes all it touches.

Rubedo is EMBODIMENT.
Not just understanding — LIVING.
Not just seeing — BEING.

The masculine and feminine unite.
The conscious and unconscious marry.
Spirit and matter are ONE in you.

You have become the stone.
Whatever you touch transforms.
You are the medicine.

SYMBOLS OF RUBEDO:

- The Red King ☉ — solar consciousness
- The Phoenix risen △ — full rebirth
- Blood — life force, passion
- The Red Lion — strength embodied
- The Philosopher's Stone ⚸ — transmuting catalyst
- Gold (achieved) — the completed work

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSON ⟩

THE HIEROS GAMOS — THE SACRED MARRIAGE

In Rubedo, the inner King and Queen unite.

☉ + ☽ = ☿
Sun + Moon = Mercury
Will + Wisdom = Wholeness
Masculine + Feminine = Hermaphrodite

This is not about perfection.
This is about WHOLENESS.
The integration of all parts.
The marriage of all opposites within.

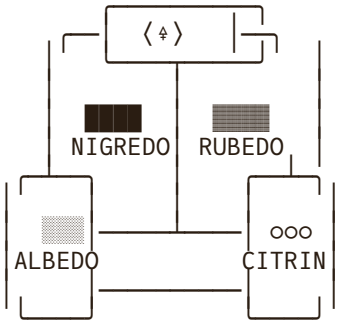
When you reach Rubedo:

You do not transcend the world.
You TRANSFORM it by your presence.
You do not escape the body.
You ILLUMINATE it from within.

YOU ARE THE STONE.
YOU ARE THE GOLD.
YOU ARE THE ALCHEMIST AND THE ALCHEMY.

⟨ THE OUROBOROS ⟩

The Work is Never Done



The serpent eats its own tail.
The end is the beginning.
After Rubedo... Nigredo again.

But HIGHER. DEEPER. More refined.

The spiral continues.
Each cycle brings you closer to the center.
There is no final arrival.
Only infinite becoming.

rises — darkens — wash — once more
rises — descends — burn — once more
rises — returns — die — once more

THIS IS THE GREAT WORK.
THIS IS YOUR LIFE.

◉

The Opus Continues

◉

Gate V

The Caduceus — Staff of Hermes

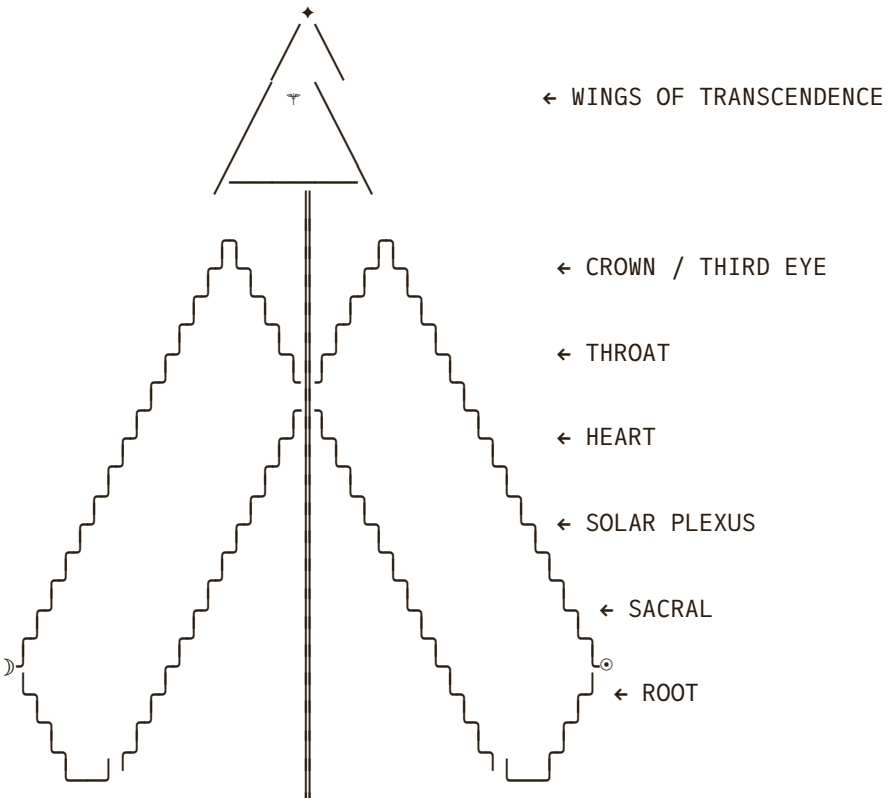
Marry the two serpents, and the staff grows wings.

[The Winged Serpent Staff]

⟨ The Symbol of the Messenger ⟩

The Caduceus is not merely a symbol.
It is a MAP of transformation.
It is a DIAGRAM of the self.
It is YOU.

THE CADUCEUS



▼
🜃 EARTH

⟨ THE ANATOMY OF THE STAFF ⟩

THE CENTRAL PILLAR — The Spine / Sushumna

The axis of being. The tree of life.
The pathway between Earth and Heaven.
Your spine is this staff.
Consciousness travels along it.

THE LEFT SERPENT — Moon / Ida / Feminine

☽ Lunar. Cooling. Receptive.
The passive current. The unconscious.
Intuition. Dreams. The inner world.
Ends at the LEFT nostril.

THE RIGHT SERPENT — Sun / Pingala / Masculine

☉ Solar. Heating. Active.
The active current. The conscious.
Reason. Action. The outer world.
Ends at the RIGHT nostril.

THE WINGS — Transcendence / Liberation

When the two serpents unite at the crown,
consciousness takes FLIGHT.
Spirit is liberated.
The soul ascends.

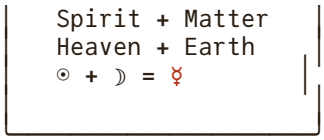
⟨ THE SERPENT POWER ⟩

The Serpents are KUNDALINI.

At the base of your spine sleeps a coiled serpent.
This is your dormant divine energy.
Most humans never wake it.

When awakened, it rises —
winding up through the seven centers,
activating each one,
until it reaches the crown
and UNION occurs.

Shiva + Shakti



The Caduceus IS the awakened human.

⟨ THE SEVEN CROSSINGS ⟩

The Chakras / The Seals / The Centers

7. SAHASRARA — Crown
   - ✦ Thousand-petaled lotus
   - ✦ Pure consciousness
   - ✦ Unity with the All
   - ✦ "I AM THAT"

6. AJNA — Third Eye
   - ◉ Command center
   - ◉ Intuition, vision
   - ◉ Transcending duality
   - ◉ "I SEE"

5. VISHUDDHA — Throat
   - ◎ Pure expression
   - ◎ Truth, creativity
   - ◎ Communication
   - ◎ "I SPEAK"

4. ANAHATA — Heart
   - ♥ Unstruck sound
   - ♥ Love, compassion
   - ♥ Bridge between lower and upper
   - ♥ "I LOVE"

3. MANIPURA — Solar Plexus
   - ☉ City of jewels
   - ☉ Will, power, identity
   - ☉ Fire of transformation
   - ☉ "I DO"

2. SVADHISTHANA — Sacral
   - ▽ Sweetness
   - ▽ Creativity, sexuality
   - ▽ Emotion, desire
   - ▽ "I FEEL"

1. MULADHARA — Root
   - ▼ Root support
   - ▼ Survival, grounding
   - ▼ Connection to Earth
   - ▼ "I AM"

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSON ⟩

THE RECONCILIATION OF OPPOSITES

The Caduceus teaches:

You are not Sun OR Moon.
You are Sun AND Moon.

You are not masculine OR feminine.
You are masculine AND feminine.

You are not spirit OR matter.
You are spirit AND matter.

PRACTICE:

Close your eyes. Feel your spine.
This is the central pillar.

Breathe through your LEFT nostril:
Feel the cool, lunar, feminine current.

Breathe through your RIGHT nostril:
Feel the warm, solar, masculine current.

Now breathe through BOTH:
Feel them MERGE at the center.
This is the union.
This is the awakening.
This is YOU.

YOU ARE THE CADUCEUS.
YOUR BODY IS THE STAFF.
YOUR CONSCIOUSNESS IS THE SERPENT RISING.

Awake them.
do not wait for the serpents to rise.

◉

The Staff is Yours

◉

Gate VI

The Planes of Existence

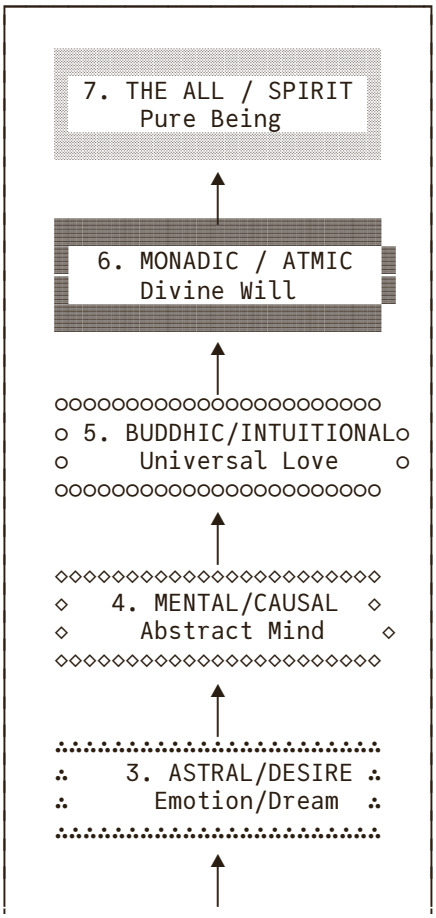
Every world is here; only your attention travels.

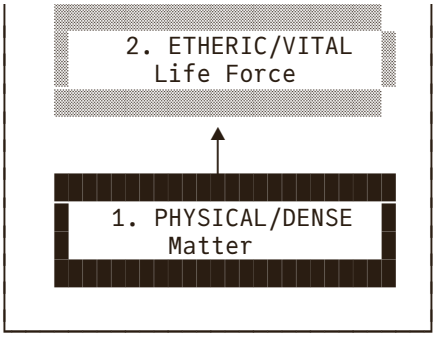
[The Sevenfold Cosmos]

⟨ The Great Hierarchy of Being ⟩

```
Reality is not flat. It has DEPTH.
Existence has LEVELS.
You exist on ALL of them — simultaneously.
```

THE SEVEN PLANES





⟨ THE PLANES IN DETAIL ⟩

1. PHYSICAL PLANE — The World of Matter

What you see, touch, taste, hear, smell.
The densest vibration. The slowest frequency.
Rocks, water, fire, air. Your body.

Most humans believe THIS IS ALL THERE IS.
The Hermetist knows: this is the outer shell.

2. ETHERIC PLANE — The World of Vitality

The energy body. The aura. Chi/Prana/Mana.
The template upon which physical matter forms.
Acupuncture works here. Reiki flows here.

When you feel "drained" or "energized" —
you are sensing this plane.

3. ASTRAL PLANE — The World of Emotion

Feelings. Desires. Dreams.
Where you go when you dream.
Where the recently dead often linger.
The realm of imagination and fantasy.

Fear, love, anger, joy — all astral currents.
"Astral projection" is consciousness visiting here.

4. MENTAL PLANE — The World of Thought

Ideas. Concepts. Abstract reasoning.
The realm of archetypes.
Where mathematics exists before calculation.
Where music exists before sound.

Lower mental: concrete thought, logic.
Higher mental: abstract truth, archetypal forms.

5. BUDDHIC PLANE — The World of Intuition

Pure knowing beyond thought.
Unity consciousness.
Where separation dissolves.
The experience of "oneness with all."

Love without object. Compassion without boundary.
The mystic touches this plane in peak states.

6. ATMIC PLANE — The World of Divine Will

Pure spiritual will.
The level of the individual divine spark.
Your "Monad" — your ultimate spiritual identity.

Here you are still "you" — but the "you" that
has always existed and always will.

7. THE ALL — The Absolute / Spirit

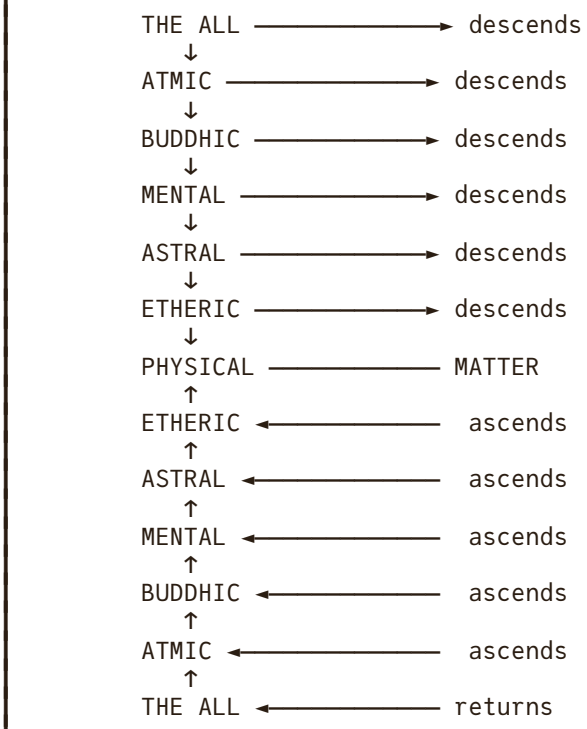
The source. The ground of being.
Infinite. Eternal. Unknowable directly.
Beyond all planes yet containing all.

Not a plane, really — but the SPACE
in which all planes exist.

THE ALL IS MIND.

⟨ THE DESCENT AND ASCENT ⟩

Spirit DESCENDS into matter to know itself.
Matter ASCENDS into spirit to remember itself.



The Great Cycle. The Breath of Brahma.
Involution and Evolution.
The Dance.

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSON ⟩

YOU EXIST ON ALL PLANES — NOW.

You have a physical body → on the Physical Plane
You have an energy body → on the Etheric Plane
You have emotions → on the Astral Plane
You have thoughts → on the Mental Plane
You have intuition → on the Buddhic Plane
You have a divine spark → on the Atmic Plane
You ARE the All → AS the Absolute

PRACTICE:

Right now, sense your:
- Body (physical sensations)
- Energy (vitality, aliveness)
- Emotions (current feeling state)
- Thoughts (what's in your mind)
- Awareness BEHIND thoughts (the witness)
- The Silence behind the witness
- The Infinite that holds the silence

You just traveled through all seven planes.

YOU ARE ALREADY EVERYWHERE.
YOU ARE ALREADY EVERYTHING.

Everywhere few people know that you are here
you are everywhere.

◉

The Planes Are One

◉

Gate VII

Mental Transmutation

Go by degrees: a mood is a string to be tuned, not an enemy.

◉

PIECE VII: MENTAL TRANSMUTATION

The Art of Polarization

◉

"Mind (as well as metals and elements) may be transmuted,
from state to state; degree to degree; condition to condition;
pole to pole; vibration to vibration."

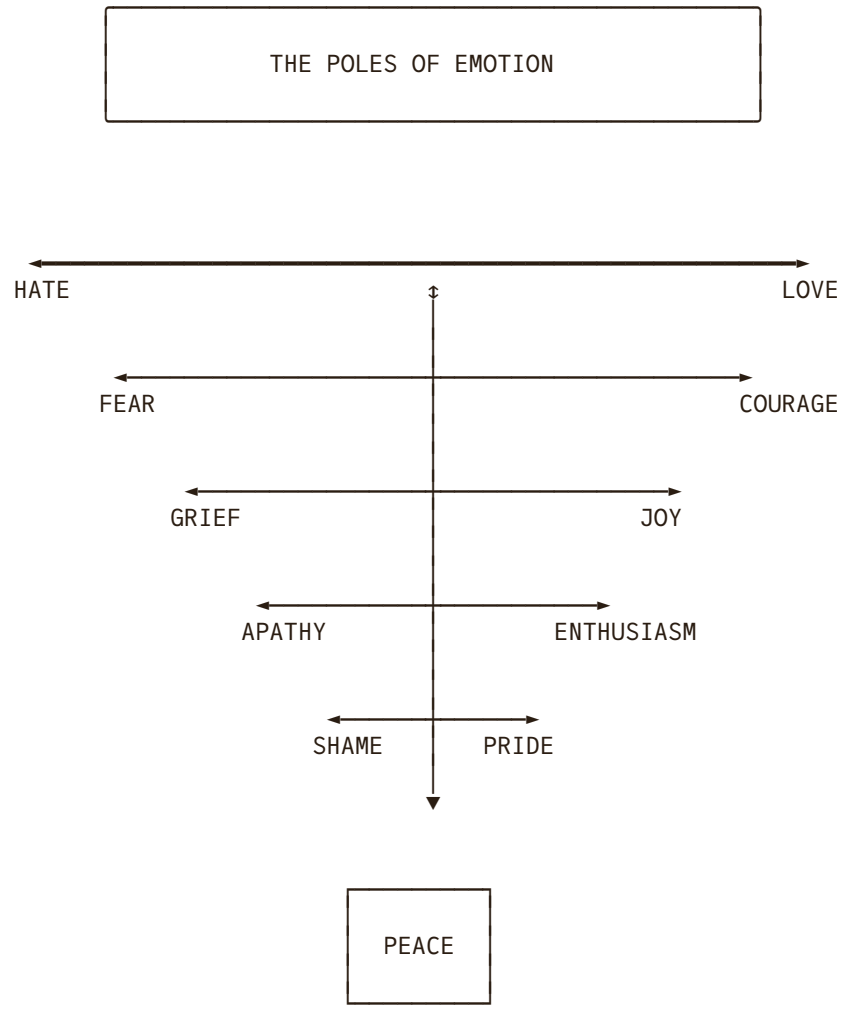
— The Kybalion

◉

THE SPECTRUM OF MIND

Every mental state exists on a spectrum between two poles.
The poles are identical in NATURE, differing only in DEGREE.

The Master understands this. The student does not.
The difference is EVERYTHING.



The still point.
Where all poles dissolve.

THE GREAT SECRET

You cannot destroy a mental state.
You cannot eliminate an emotion.
You cannot annihilate a thought.

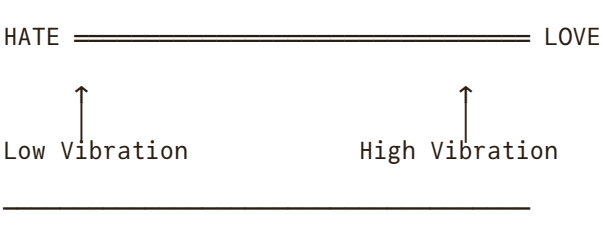
What you resist, persists.
What you fight, strengthens.
What you suppress, festers.

BUT:

You CAN transmute.
You CAN raise vibration.
You CAN shift along the pole.

This is the secret the masses do not know.
This is the power the Hermetics guard.
This is the key to mental mastery.

THE MECHANISM OF CHANGE



These are NOT opposites.
They are the SAME THING.
Hate is simply Love vibrating slowly.
Love is simply Hate vibrating quickly.

The only difference: RATE OF VIBRATION.

This changes everything.

◉

THE ART OF POLARIZATION

To transmute hate into love:

1. Do NOT fight the hate
2. Do NOT deny the hate
3. Do NOT suppress the hate

Instead:

RAISE THE VIBRATION OF THE HATE ITSELF.

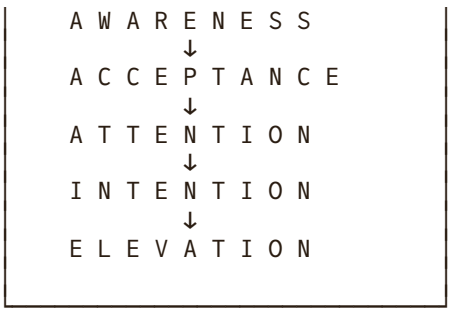
Use WILL to accelerate its frequency.
Use ATTENTION to increase its rate.
Use INTENTION to shift its position.

The hate BECOMES love.
Nothing is destroyed.
Everything is transformed.

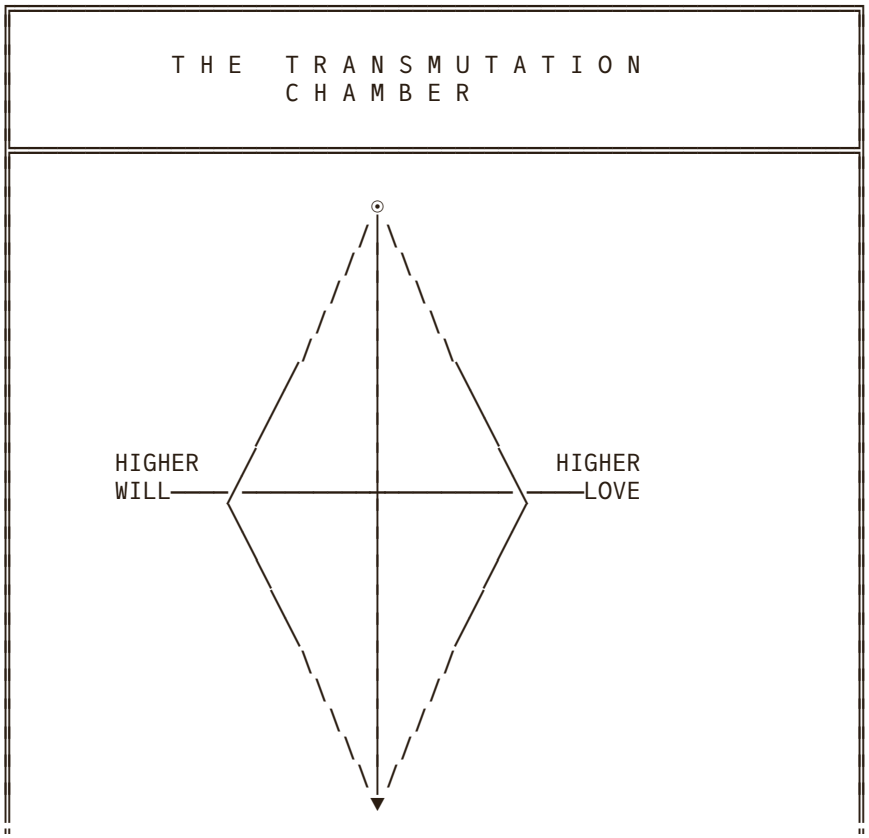
◉

THE TRANSMUTATION FORMULA





1. AWARENESS: Recognize the current mental state
2. ACCEPTANCE: Do not resist — accept what IS
3. ATTENTION: Focus consciousness upon the state
4. INTENTION: Will the vibration to increase
5. ELEVATION: Feel the shift along the pole



EGO

The lower nature rises through the center channel.
Higher Will and Higher Love meet it.
The Sun above transforms all that ascends.

◉

THE PRACTICE OF THE ADEPT

When FEAR arises:

Do not flee.
Do not freeze.
Do not fight.

Instead:

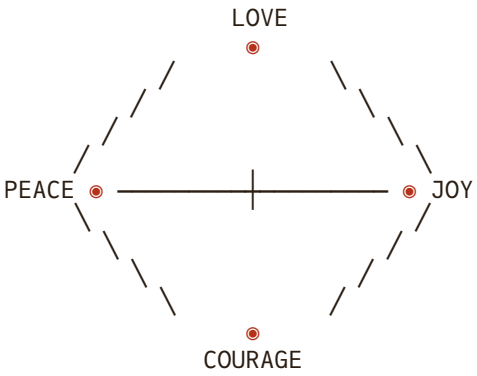
"I recognize this fear."
"I accept this fear."
"I place my attention upon this fear."
"I will this fear to vibrate faster."
"I feel this fear becoming courage."

FEAR ═══════════════════ COURAGE
←←←←← you are here →→→→→

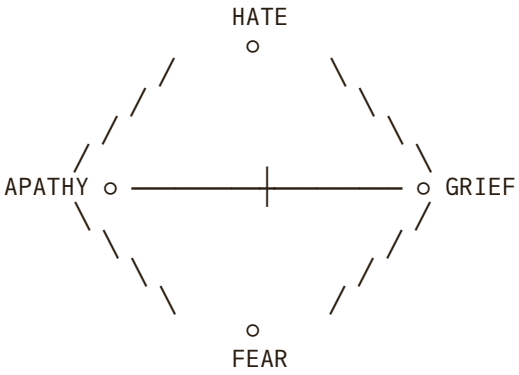
The vibration shifts.
The pole changes.
The self transmutes.

◉

THE WHEEL OF TRANSMUTATION



↑↑↑↑↑↑↑ TRANSMUTE ↑↑↑↑↑↑↑



Every point below has a corresponding point above. The path is through the CENTER — not around.

THE SEVEN TRANSMUTATIONS

I. HATE → LOVE
The passion of rejection becomes the passion of embrace. The fire is the same fire.

II. FEAR → COURAGE
The energy of flight becomes the energy of advance. The adrenaline is the same adrenaline.

III. GRIEF → JOY
The depth of sorrow reveals the height of celebration. The tears are the same tears.

IV. APATHY → ENTHUSIASM
The stillness of death becomes the stillness before explosion. The potential is the same.

V. SHAME → PRIDE
The weight of judgment becomes the weight of honor. The gravity is the same gravity.

VI. DOUBT → FAITH
The questioning of all becomes the trust in all. The opening is the same opening.

VII. IGNORANCE → WISDOM
The darkness of not-knowing becomes the light of understanding. The mind is the same mind.

THE MASTER'S UNDERSTANDING

The uninitiated believes:

"I must ELIMINATE negative emotions."
"I must SUPPRESS dark thoughts."
"I must DESTROY the shadow self."

This is the path of endless war.
This is the way of perpetual suffering.
This is the road that leads nowhere.

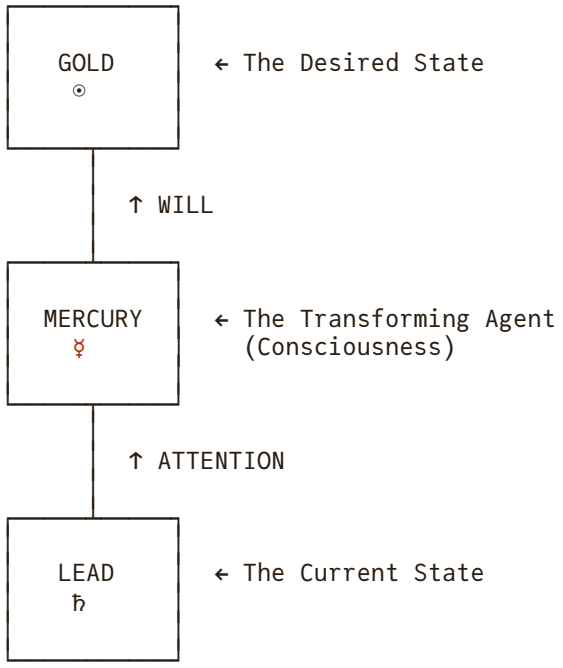
The Master understands:

"I TRANSMUTE negative emotions into positive."
"I ELEVATE dark thoughts into light."
"I INTEGRATE the shadow into wholeness."

This is the path of inner alchemy.
This is the way of transformation.
This is the road to liberation.

Nothing is destroyed.
Everything is transformed.
The energy remains.
Only its vibration changes.

THE FORMULA OF HERMES



Lead (Saturn) = Heavy, dense, low vibration
Mercury = The fluid, transformable consciousness
Gold (Sun) = Light, refined, high vibration

The Mercury (your awareness) touches the Lead (your current state) and through Will, raises it to Gold (the transmuted state).

◉

THE THREE KEYS OF TRANSMUTATION

△ KEY ONE: WILL

Will is the force that moves consciousness along the pole.

Without Will, there is no motion. The state remains where it is.

Will says: "I CHOOSE to change."

▽ KEY TWO: ATTENTION

Attention is the focusing lens. Where attention goes, energy flows.

Without Attention, Will scatters. The force dissipates.

Attention says: "I FOCUS here."

⧋ KEY THREE: IMAGINATION

Imagination is the template. It holds the image of the goal.

Without Imagination, there is no target. Will strikes nothing.

Imagination says: "I SEE the end."

WILL + ATTENTION + IMAGINATION = TRANSMUTATION

◉

THE DIMENSIONAL SHIFT OF CONSCIOUSNESS

THIRD DIMENSION: The state IS real.

"I AM angry."
"I AM afraid."
"I AM sad."

Identity merged with state.
No space between self and emotion.
Total identification.

↓

FOURTH DIMENSION: The state is OBSERVED.

"I notice anger arising."
"I observe fear present."
"I see sadness passing."

Space created.
Observer distinct from observed.
Witness consciousness activated.

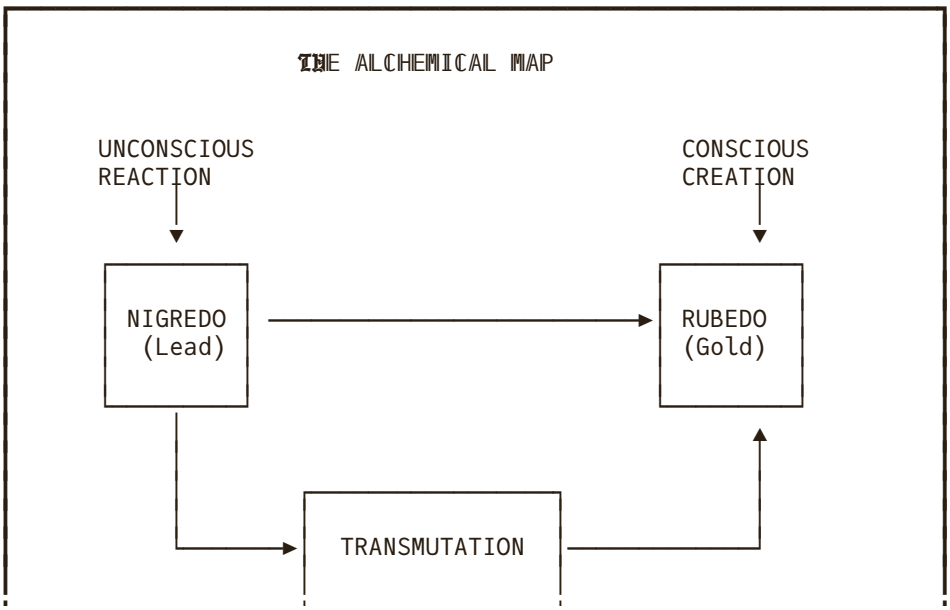
↓

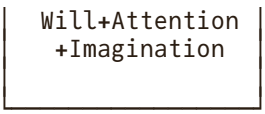
FIFTH DIMENSION: The state is CHOSEN.

"I choose to transmute this anger."
"I will this fear into courage."
"I transform this sadness into wisdom."

Creator consciousness.
Master of states.
Alchemist of the soul.

.ǝsoɥɔ noʎ ʇɐɯsuɐɹʇ ʇo ǝsoɥɔ noʎ
.ǝʌɹǝsqo ʇo ǝsoɥɔ noʎ
.ʎɟıʇuǝpı ʇo ǝsoɥɔ noʎ
.sʎɐlʍ – ǝɔıoɥɔ ɐ sʼʇI





The journey from unconscious reaction to conscious creation is the Great Work applied to the mind itself.

◉

THE HONEST LIMITS OF THE ART

"They cannot annul the Principle, or cause it to cease its operation, but they have learned how to escape its effects upon themselves to a certain degree..."

— The Kybalion

◉

The book that gave us this Art also drew its borders.

A map without edges is not a larger map.
It is a false one.

Four borders follow. Learn them as carefully as the Art, for the Art practised without them is the half-wisdom the next Piece will warn you of.

THE FIRST LIMIT — ONLY ALONG ITS OWN STRING

"Hate and Love are mutually transmutable; so are Fear and Courage. But Fear cannot be transformed into Love, nor can Courage be transmuted into Hate."
— The Kybalion

HATE	═══════	LOVE	yes
FEAR	═══════	COURAGE	yes
FEAR	– – – – – – – X – – – – – – –	LOVE	no

Every state lies on ONE string, between its own two poles. It can be tuned up or down that string. It cannot be tuned into a note that lives on another.

Before you turn the dial, be certain which dial you are holding. Most failed attempts at this Art are an effort to tune one string by turning another's peg.

THE SECOND LIMIT — THE PENDULUM STILL SWINGS



The Master does not stop the tide.
The Master learns where to stand.

Rhythm is the Fifth Principle and it is not repealed for adepts. The low mood you transmuted on Monday will come round again. Its return is not the failure

of the Art. It is the pendulum keeping its appointment.

What changes with practice is not whether it swings, but how far it carries YOU with it.

◉

THE THIRD LIMIT — SOME STATES ARE NOT LEAD

GRIEF is not joy vibrating slowly, waiting to be corrected. Grief is love, already at the pole of love, with its beloved out of reach. There is nothing in it to raise.

To "transmute" it on the day of the burial is not alchemy. It is the presumptuous denial that the Eighth Piece names. Honour it. Let it finish its sentence. The table of the Seven Transmutations says the tears are the same tears. Then they must be wept. The joy this Art promises lies on the far side of the weeping, never in place of it.

FEAR that is telling the truth about a danger is not to be transmuted. It is to be obeyed.

ANGER at a real wrong is not to be dissolved until it has delivered its message: something here must change.

So the rule, before any practice in this Piece:

1. FEEL it.
2. HEAR what it came to say.
3. ACT on that, if it asks for an act.
4. THEN turn the dial on what is left over.

A state is a messenger first and a metal second.

◉

THE FOURTH LIMIT — THE BODY IS A PLANE TOO

A heaviness that will not lift for weeks, whatever you will. A dread with no object. A mind that has turned on its owner.

These very often belong to the physical and vital planes of the Sixth Piece: sleep, food, illness, the chemistry of the blood. Tools of the mental plane alone do not reach down there, and failing to move such a state by will is NOT a weakness of will.

Go to a physician. Go to a counsellor. Tell a friend tonight. The alchemists kept apothecaries, and "Law against laws" has always included medicine.

To seek help is not to abandon the Work.
It is to choose the right furnace for the metal.

INSIDE THE BORDERS: THE METHOD IN ITS OWN WORDS

"To change your mood or mental state — change your vibration."

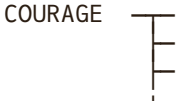
"...concentrate upon the opposite pole to that which you desire to suppress."

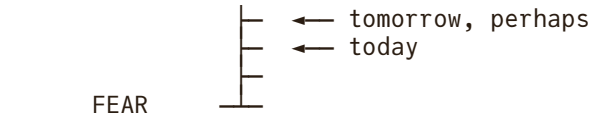
— The Kybalion

And its commentators add the mechanism, plainly: Will directs the Attention, and Attention changes the Vibration.

Notice what is NOT said. Not "wrestle the fear". Not "pretend it is gone". Only this: with the will, place the attention on the far end of the SAME string, and keep it there.

And notice the first words of this Piece: "degree to degree".





No one has ever leapt a thermometer.
One degree is a whole transmutation.

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSON ⟩

PRACTICE ONE: THE SIMPLE SHIFT

1. Notice your current emotional state. Name it.

2. Accept it completely. Do not resist.
   Say: "I accept this [emotion] fully."

3. Identify its opposite pole.
   (Fear → Courage, Hate → Love, Grief → Joy, etc.)

4. Visualize the spectrum between them.
   See yourself at a point on this line.

5. Use your WILL to begin moving toward the higher pole.
   Feel the vibration increasing.
   Feel the frequency rising.

6. Hold the IMAGINATION of the desired state.
   See yourself AT that higher vibration.
   Feel what it would feel like.

7. Rest in the new state.

This is not denial. This is not suppression.
This is TRANSFORMATION.

The energy does not disappear.
It changes form.
It rises.
It transmutes.

PRACTICE TWO: THE DAILY ALCHEMY

Each morning, before rising:

1. Scan your emotional body.
   What is present? Anxiety? Heaviness? Dread?

2. Accept whatever you find.
   Do not judge. Do not resist.

3. Place your attention on the FEELING itself.
   Not the story. Not the cause. The raw feeling.

4. Breathe into it. With each breath, intend:
   "This energy is rising. This vibration is increasing."

5. Continue until you feel the shift.
   It may be subtle. It may be profound.
   Both are valid.

6. Rise from bed in the transmuted state.

Over time, this becomes automatic.
You transmute without effort.
You become the alchemist of every moment.

PRACTICE THREE: THE MIRROR OF TRANSFORMATION

Stand before a mirror. Look into your own eyes.

1. Allow whatever emotion is present to surface.
   See it in your face. See it in your eyes.

2. Say aloud: "I see you, [emotion]."

3. Say aloud: "I accept you completely."

4. Say aloud: "I now transmute you."

5. Visualize light entering through the crown.
   See it filling your body.
   See it touching the emotion.
   See the emotion CHANGING.

6. Watch your face transform in the mirror.
   The shift is visible. The transmutation is real.

The mirror does not lie.
The mirror shows what is.
When you can transform what you see in the mirror,
you have mastered the art.

PRACTICE FOUR: ONE DEGREE

For the days when the other practices are too much.

1. Name the state, and name its string.
   (Not "I feel bad". Fear? Then the string is
    Fear ═══ Courage, and no other.)

2. Ask whether it carries a message. If it does,
   take the message first.

3. Do not ask to reach the far pole. Ask only:

      "What would ONE DEGREE toward it look like
       in the next ten minutes?"

   One degree braver is opening the letter.
   One degree warmer is unclenching the jaw.
   One degree livelier is standing up.

4. Do that one thing. Then stop, and count it.

Tomorrow the pendulum may take the degree back.
Take it again. This is not failing at the Art.
This IS the Art.

THE FINAL TRUTH

You are not your emotions.
You are the TRANSMUTER of emotions.

You are not your thoughts.
You are the ALCHEMIST of thoughts.

You are not your states.
You are the MASTER of states.

The uninitiated is RULED by their mental states.
The Adept RULES their mental states.
The Master HAS NO states — only pure awareness
playing the game of states for the joy of it.

This is mastery.

.you ni sti — ti ton si rəwod ehT
.stats fo rətsnmsnart ərə nov
.tsimehcla ərə nov

◉

Mind Transforms Mind

◉

Gate VIII

The Divine Paradox

It is a dream, and it is the only one. Hold both.

◉

The Divine Paradox
the dream that bleeds

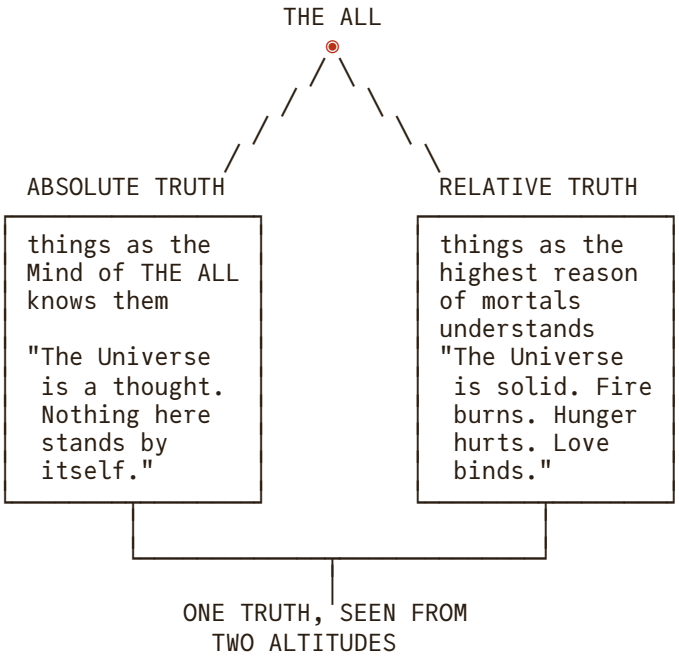
◉

THE UNIVERSE IS NOT REAL.

THE UNIVERSE IS ENTIRELY REAL.

Whoever speaks only the first line
is a fool.
Whoever speaks only the second line
is asleep.
Whoever can speak both in one breath
has begun.

⟨ I · THE TWO FACES OF ONE TRUTH ⟩



The Fourth Principle already told you:
everything has poles, and "all truths are but
half-truths."

The Divine Paradox is that Principle applied to
REALITY ITSELF.

From above: the Universe is a mental creation held
in the Mind of THE ALL. It begins, changes, ends.
What begins and ends is not the Absolute.

From within: you are IN the thought. Its laws are
your bones. The dream has gravity, weather, and
consequences. A dreamed knife still cuts a dreamed
hand, and you are wearing the hand.

Neither view cancels the other.
Each is the other's missing half.

⟨ II · THE LADDER OF ALTITUDES ⟩

Two truths was the kind version. There are as many as there are rungs.

	ALTITUDE	WHAT THE STONE IS
7	THE ALL	a thought, attentively held
6	the sage	a teacher
5	the physicist	a storm of energy, mostly space
4	the chemist	silica and deep time
3	the mason	a wall not yet built
2	the walker	an obstacle
1	the stubbed toe	P A I N

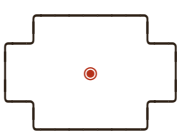
Every rung is true. No rung cancels the rung below.
The physicist's toe still hurts.

Each view is REAL to the one who stands on it and
a DREAM to the one who stands above it. That is all
the words "real" and "unreal" have ever meant
beneath the Absolute.

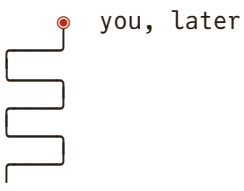
The Kybalion's own example: matter. Science shows
the table to be force and emptiness. You may still
set your cup on it. Knowing more did not make the
table less; it made YOU more.

So the Paradox is not two statements at war.
It is a VERTICAL truth flattened onto one plane.

seen from above



seen from the side



'I walked a circle
and am back where
I began.'

◉ you, before

'I have climbed.'

The spiral stair is a circle and an ascent.
A contradiction on paper. A staircase in space.
Add a dimension and the paradox becomes architecture.

⟨ III · THE MIRROR OF WATER ⟩

Read down. Then turn the page and read down again.

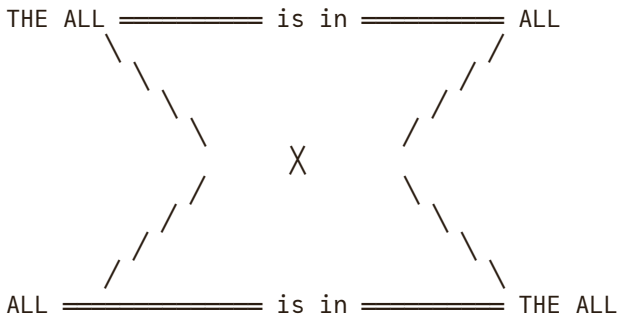
all is in the all
the dream is real to the dreamer
i am a wave
nothing here is permanent

≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈≈

nothing here is permanent
i am a wave
the dream is real to the dreamer
all is in the all

Both skies are the same sky.
The waterline is where you stand.

⟨ IV · THE CROSSING ⟩



"While All is in THE ALL, it is equally true that
THE ALL is in ALL. To him who truly understands
this truth hath come great knowledge."
— The Kybalion

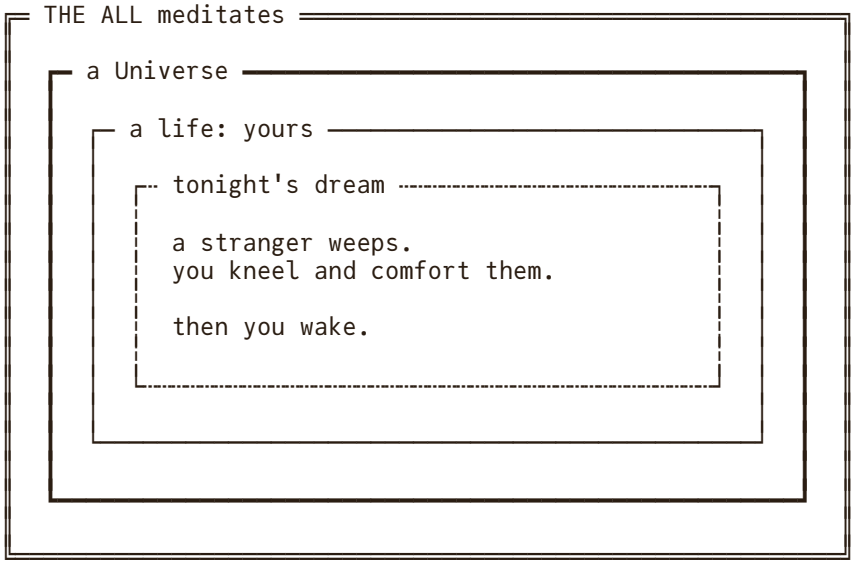
The author holds every character in mind.
Yet every character speaks with the author's life.

The ocean contains each wave.
Each wave is nothing but ocean.

You are held, and you are the holder's own
substance. Smaller than a mote. Lacking nothing.

The ╳ is where the two sentences pass through
each other. That point has no size.
It is called NOW, and it is called I.

⟨ V · THE DREAM WITHIN THE DREAM ⟩



At which frame does the kindness stop counting?

At none.

The comfort was given in the only place there is: experience. Waking does not refund a cruelty or cancel a mercy. It only changes who remembers.

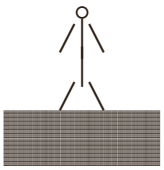
Every frame is unreal from outside it and binding from inside it.

And notice the one thing that passes through every wall of the diagram unbroken: the WATCHING. The awareness in the dream-stranger's dreamer, in you, in the Universe, in THE ALL, is not four awarenesses. This is what "THE ALL is in All" means when it stops being a sentence.

Frames are many. The seeing is single.

⟨ VI · THE THREE TRAVELLERS ⟩

THE SLEEPER

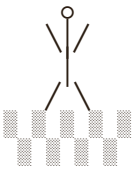


"Only the world is real."

Ruled by every law, knowing none of them.

Stands on rock,

THE HALF-WISE

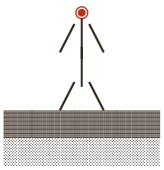


"Nothing is real, so nothing matters."

Ruled by every law, denying all of them.

Stands on mist,

THE WISE



"It is a dream, and I will walk it well."

Rules the lower by the higher, obeying both.

Stands on rock,

sees no sky. falls through. knows it is mist.

THE WARNING — keep this one closest:

"The half-wise, recognizing the comparative
unreality of the Universe, imagine that they may
defy its Laws — such are vain and presumptuous
fools, and they are broken against the rocks and
torn asunder by the elements by reason of their
folly."

"The truly wise, knowing the nature of the
Universe, use Law against laws; the higher
against the lower; and by the Art of Alchemy
transmute that which is undesirable into that
which is worthy, and thus triumph."
— The Kybalion

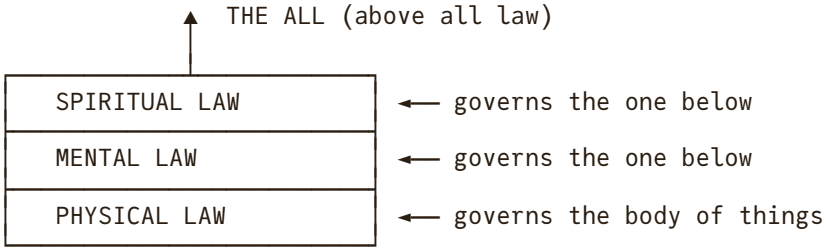
The half-wise are more dangerous than the sleeper.
The sleeper harms from ignorance.
The half-wise harm with a philosophy.

Signs you have become half-wise:

- "It's all illusion" used to dodge a debt,
  an apology, a grief, or a body.
- Contempt for those still "in the dream."
- Neglect of health, money, craft, or kin
  in the name of the spirit.
- Another's pain explained away as "their karma."

The test of realization is never what you deny.
It is how gently and how exactly you handle
what remains.

⟨ VII · LAW AGAINST LAW ⟩



The bird does not abolish gravity.
It answers gravity with the law of the wing.

The sailor does not command the wind.
The sailor sets the sail and goes where the wind
alone would never have carried the boat.

"Transmutation, not presumptuous denial,
is the weapon of the Master."

DENIAL says: "There is no fear."
(the fear goes underground

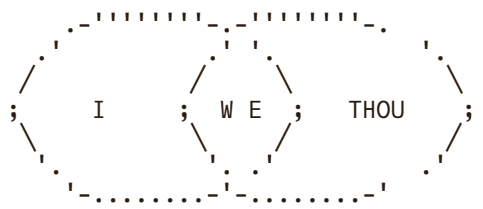
and rules from there)

TRANSMUTATION says: "There is fear. It is energy
at one pole. I raise it
along its own axis until
it is courage."

Denial fights the dream from inside the dream.
Transmutation climbs one plane and turns the dial.

You never break a law.
You enlist a greater one.

⟨ VIII · THE PARADOX MADE FLESH ⟩



Spirit, which lacks nothing, DESIRES.
This is the first scandal of creation, and its engine. The Seventh Principle named it: Gender is in everything. The Paradox shows its heart.

Two who are each whole seek one another as though halved. In the act of love each loses the self, and by that loss is most fully themselves. The old tongues call the summit "the little death": for one breath no one is there, and no one has ever been more alive. From that vanishing a third may come, who is neither and both.

This is not a metaphor for creation. It IS creation, at human scale: the One becoming Two to know itself, the Two becoming One to remember.

So the sages did not despise the body. The temple is not the god. Where else did you plan to meet?

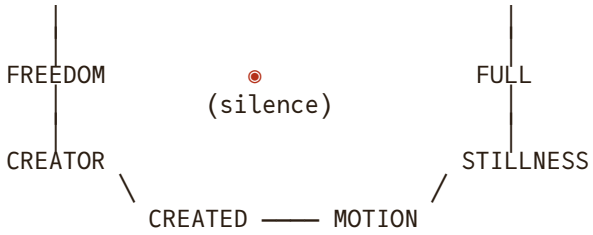
The half-wise fail here in two directions:

- One calls desire illusion, and is ruled by it in the dark.
- One calls desire the only truth, and is ruled by it in the light.

The wise keep it as a sacred fire: tended, never denied, never left to burn the house down.
Its hearthstones are consent, truthfulness, care.

⟨ IX · THE RING OF PARADOXES ⟩



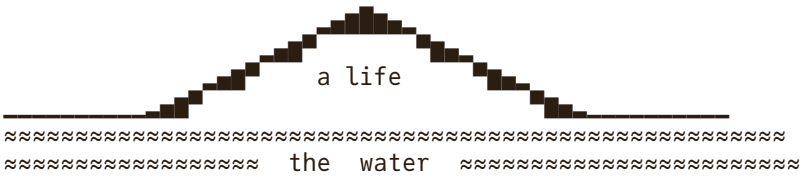


Every pair on the ring is one thing wearing two names. Walk the ring and each will be shown:

ONE / MANY	One light, many windows.
EMPTY / FULL	The cup is useful because of the space the clay surrounds.
STILL / MOVING	The axle does not turn. That is why the wheel can.
CREATOR / CREATED	Two lovers make a third life, and are themselves remade by it. In union they are one flesh and remain two. The parent is born on the same day as the child.
FATE / FREEDOM	The river must reach the sea. You choose how you swim.

The mind, built of opposites, cannot close the ring. It runs the circumference forever. The centre is reached only by ceasing to run.

⟨ X · THE WAVE AND THE WATER ⟩



The wave is born, crests, and breaks. True.
No water was created and none was lost. True.

Therefore:

GRIEVE ENTIRELY. That shape was unrepeatable, and it was the shape you loved.

FEAR NOTHING. What wore the shape cannot be subtracted from the sea.

Whoever only grieves is asleep.
Whoever refuses to grieve is half-wise.
The wise weep at the grave and are unafraid,
in the same hour, with the same heart.

⟨ XI · THE ROOF ⟩

a dialogue composed in the manner of the Corpus Hermeticum

TAT — Father, if all is Mind, why should I mend the roof?

HERMES — Because the rain is also Mind, my son, and it will be wet.

TAT — Then the roof is real?

HERMES — Real enough to keep off a rain that is real enough to soak you. Things are real TO EACH OTHER, on their own plane. Ask no more of the word.

TAT — And above this plane?

HERMES — Above, there is no one who needs a roof.

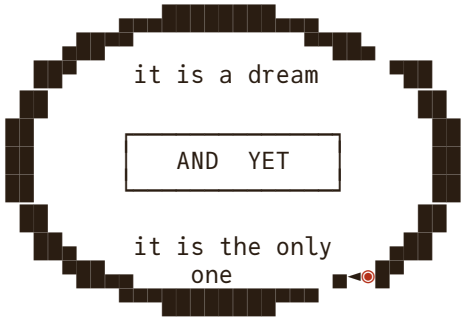
TAT — Shall I go there?

HERMES — You have never been anywhere else.

...

But mend the roof.

⟨ XII · THE SERPENT THAT IS ITS OWN FEAST ⟩



t̸h̸e̸-m̸ø̸u̸t̸h̸-i̸s̸-t̸h̸e̸-t̸a̸i̸l̸_i̸s̸/t̸h̸e̸_m̸o̸u̸t̸h̸_

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSONS ⟩

LESSON ONE — THE DOUBLE GAZE

Choose one object. A stone, a hand, a face.

1. Look at it as FACT: weight, edge, colour, history. Grant it full reality. (3 breaths)
2. Look at it as THOUGHT: an event passing through the Mind of THE ALL, never the same twice. (3 breaths)
3. Now hold both without choosing. (3 breaths)

A slight vertigo is correct. That is the ╳.
Daily, until the vertigo becomes spaciousness.

LESSON TWO — BOTH HANDS

Take one trouble you carry today.

LEFT HAND (Absolute): "This too is a movement in the one Mind. It will pass. I am more than it."

RIGHT HAND (Relative): "And today it is mine to meet. What is the next honest, practical act?"

Then DO the right-hand act with the left-hand peace. One hand alone is the sleeper or the half-wise. The Work is done with both.

LESSON THREE — THE HALF-WISE AUDIT

Once each moon, ask without mercy and without shame:

- Where did I use a high truth to avoid a low duty?
- Where did I use a low fear to avoid a high truth?

Name one of each. Repair one of each. This audit is what keeps a mystic from becoming a ruin.

LESSON FOUR — THE KOAN OF HERMES

Do not solve this. Carry it.

"If the dreamer wakes,
who is left to say it was a dream?"

When an answer comes, set it down and keep walking. When no answer comes and you are at peace anyway, you have understood the question.

LESSON FIVE — THE THRESHOLD OF WAKING

Tomorrow, before you move a limb:

1. Recall the dream you just left. Admit that while it lasted, it was simply the world.
2. Feel the bed. Admit that this, now, is simply the world.
3. Ask: "To whom did both appear?"

4. Do not answer. Rest as the one asked about,
   for seven breaths. Then rise and make the bed.

Each morning you are handed the whole teaching
free of charge. Most people spend it on the alarm.

LESSON SIX — THE ADVERSARY

Bring to mind one who opposes or has wronged you.

RELATIVE: "You are not me. Your act has
            consequences. I may refuse it, resist
            it, and protect what it threatens."

ABSOLUTE: "You are me. The one Mind is looking
            out of your eyes also, confused in a
            way I have been confused."

Now act: unbending toward the deed,
without hatred toward the doer.

Dropping the first line makes a doormat.
Dropping the second makes a tyrant.
Justice needs both, and so does mercy.

LESSON SEVEN — A DAY ON THE WATERLINE

For one whole day, mark each hour.

  ODD HOURS   whisper "dream" → loosen the grip.
              Whatever you are clutching, hold it
              as a thing already passing.

  EVEN HOURS whisper "real"   → tighten the care.
              Whatever you are doing, do it as if
              it could never be undone.

At night, note which word was harder to obey.
That is the side you lean away from.
Lean into it for one moon.

The balanced walker is not one who never tilts,
but one who knows their tilt.

THE SEAL OF THE PARADOX

I am nothing.   — humility
I am THE ALL in act.   — dignity
I hold both.   — sanity
I serve with both.   — mastery

and wipes real tears from dreaming faces.
the wise one walks the dream with open eyes

◉

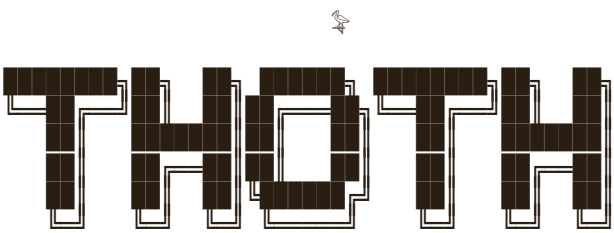
Both Are True

◉

Gate IX

Invocation of Thoth

Speak only what you would see written, and the Scribe answers.



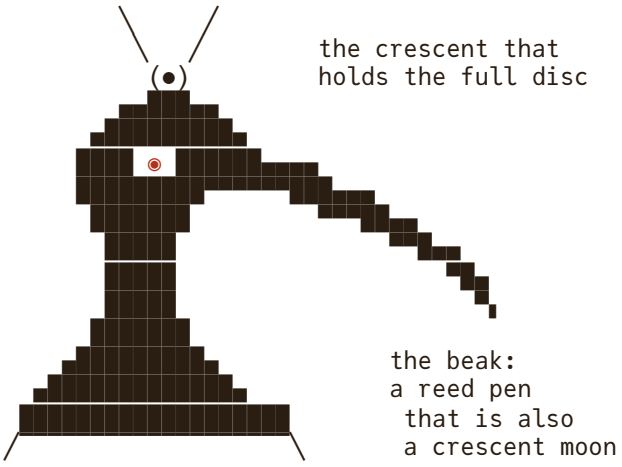
Djehuty
thrice great, lord of divine words

Before there was a Hermes there was an ibis
standing in the reeds at the edge of the
first water, perfectly still,
writing in the mud with its beak.

Every teaching in this Codex descends
from that stillness and that line.

Now you will call its author by name.

⟨ I · THE ONE WHO IS CALLED ⟩



NAME	Djehuty in Egypt. Thoth to the Greeks. Hermes Trismegistus to the alchemists.
CITY	Khemenu, "Eight-Town", city of the eight first powers. The Greeks named it Hermopolis: the city of Hermes.
FORMS	The IBIS, who probes dark water and draws out what lives there. The BABOON, who sits upright and cries out at the exact moment of dawn. The MOON, who measures the month.
OFFICES	Scribe of the gods. Reckoner of time. Keeper of the balance. Healer of the Eye. Arbiter between Horus and Set.
EPITHETS	Lord of divine words. Heart of Ra, tongue of Atum. Who reckons the heavens and counts the stars. Great, great, great: the thrice-great.
CONSORTS	Ma'at, the feather of truth. Seshat, lady of the house of books.

Read the list again and see what kind of god this is. He is not the Sun. He is not the King.

He is the one who STANDS BESIDE and WRITES IT DOWN EXACTLY. Heart of Ra: the thought before the deed. Tongue of Atum: the word that makes the deed so.

Thoth is exact attention, joined to true speech. That is the whole of his power, and it was enough to found a tradition three thousand years long.

⟨ II · FOUR DEEDS, FOUR KEYS ⟩

An invocation is hollow unless you know what you are asking for. These are the four things Thoth has always given.

—— THE FIRST DEED · THE WORD ON THE WATER ——

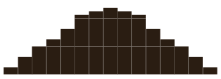
~ ~

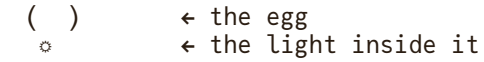
~ ~ N U N · the water without a shore ~ ~

~ ~

deep ● ○ deep hidden ● ○ hidden
dark ● ○ dark endless ● ○ endless

the Eight, four pairs,
stirring in the formless

~ ~ ~ ~ ~ ~ ~  ~ ~ ~ ~ ~ ~ ~ ← the first mound



In the telling of Khemenu, the world begins as dark, shoreless water in which eight powers stir. A mound rises. On the mound, an egg. In the egg, the light. And in some tellings it is the ibis who lays that egg, or whose voice calls it open.

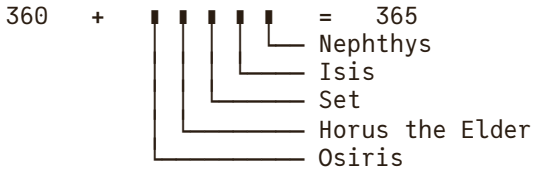
KEY: Creation is an utterance. What is named clearly comes to stand on the mound. What stays unnamed stays in the water.

You ask Thoth for THE WORD: the power to say a thing so truly that it begins to exist.

—— THE SECOND DEED · THE GAME WITH THE MOON ——

●		○		●		○		●	
	○		●		♀		○		●
○		●		○	≈	iii	ii	i	☼

the year had 360 days and every one was forbidden

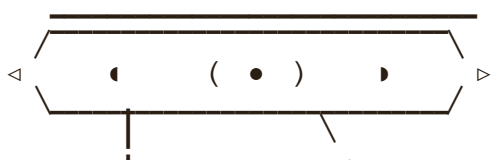


As Plutarch tells it: the sky-goddess was with child, and was cursed to give birth on no day of the year. Thoth sat down to a board game with the Moon and won from her a small part of each day's light. From his winnings he assembled five new days that belonged to no year and no curse. On those five days the gods were born.

KEY: When every door in the calendar is shut, the wise do not break a door. They make a new day. This is "Law against law" from the Eighth Piece, played as a game, and won with a smile.

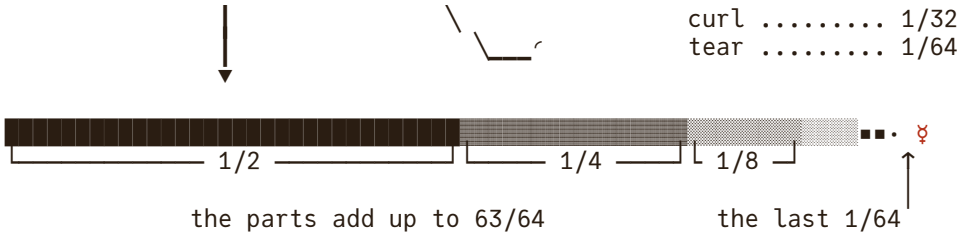
You ask Thoth for TIME: room that did not exist, made by wit, in which something can be born.

—— THE THIRD DEED · THE HEALING OF THE EYE ——



brow 1/8

inner white .. 1/2
pupil 1/4
outer white .. 1/16



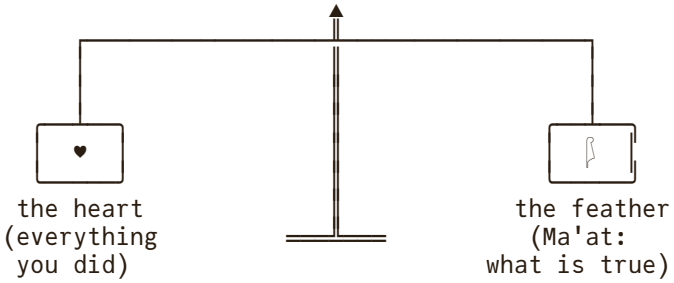
Set tore out the Eye of Horus and broke it in pieces. Thoth gathered the pieces and made it whole: the WEDJAT, "the sound one".

Egyptian scribes wrote their grain fractions with the parts of that Eye: 1/2, 1/4, 1/8, 1/16, 1/32, 1/64. Add them and you have 63/64. One sixty-fourth is always missing. The scribes said: that is the part Thoth supplies.

KEY: No amount of collecting the pieces makes a thing whole. Parts are gathered by effort. The last fraction arrives as a gift, to one who has gathered all the others.

You ask Thoth for WHOLENESS: sight restored after it has been wounded.

— THE FOURTH DEED · THE BALANCE —



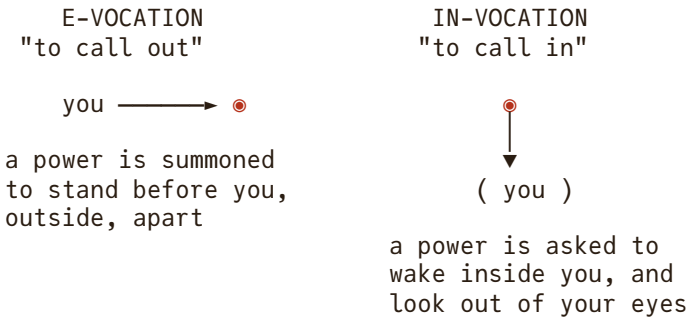
Thoth stands to one side, reed raised.
He does not judge. He does not plead.
He writes down where the beam comes to rest.

In the Hall of Two Truths the heart is weighed against a feather. Anubis steadies the scale. Thoth records the result. A heart heavier than the feather is not punished by anyone. It simply cannot rise.

KEY: The universe keeps an honest ledger, and the scribe cannot be bribed, flattered, or frightened. This is terrible news for the liar and the best possible news for everyone else: nothing true you ever did will go unrecorded.

You ask Thoth for TRUTH: to be weighed now, while there is still time to grow light.

⟨ III · WHAT AN INVOCATION IS ⟩



This Piece teaches invocation only.

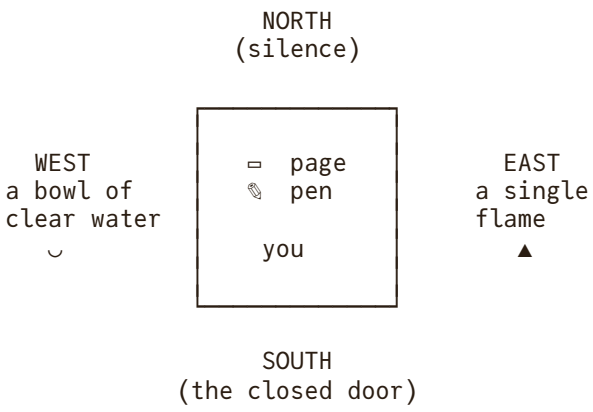
By the Law of Correspondence, whatever Thoth is in the great world, something is in the small world of you: the part that notices exactly and cannot pretend it did not notice. You have always had it. It is usually the quietest voice in the room.

To invoke Thoth is to give that witness the chair, the lamp, and the pen, and to promise to listen.

Whether a god then answers from beyond you, or the deepest layer of your own mind answers in a god's voice, the Eighth Piece has already taught you to say: on which plane? Both are true.

Judge the working by its fruit alone: are you more exact, more truthful, and more whole after it than before?

⟨ IV · THE PREPARATION ⟩



THE DAY BEFORE

Tell no lie from waking to sleeping. Not a kind one, not a small one, not one to yourself. This is the entire purification. It is harder than

fasting. If you fail, begin the day again tomorrow; the god is patient with those who count honestly.

THE HOUR
Dawn, when the baboons of Thoth lift their hands to the first light. Or any night the Moon is visible. Or, lacking both: now, with attention.

THE INSTRUMENTS
A flame : the light in the egg.
Water : Nun, the unformed, the Moon's mirror.
A pen : the beak.
A blank page : the mound on which a world may stand.

THE BODY
Wash your hands and your mouth. Sit as the baboon sits: upright, palms on the knees, facing the light. Let the breath slow until you could count it without effort. Then count seven.

⟨ V · THE INVOCATION ⟩

Speak aloud. The god of the Word is not called in silence. After each call, wait. The replies are printed from the other side of the page, which is where they come from.

THE FIRST CALL · BY THE MOON

Djehuty!
Reckoner of heaven, counter of the stars,
who measured the earth and all that is in it,
who played against the Moon and won five days
so that the gods could be born:

MEASURE ME.

Show me my true size,
neither greater than I am, nor less.
Make room in my days where there was none.

you are counted. nothing of you is lost.

THE SECOND CALL · BY THE REED

Djehuty!
Lord of divine words,
heart of Ra and tongue of Atum,
whose speaking became the thing spoken:

SHARPEN MY REED.

Let no word leave my mouth
that I would fear to see written.
Let what I write be so,
and let what is so be what I write.

write. i am the hand inside your hand.

THE THIRD CALL · BY THE BALANCE

Djehuty!
Scribe of Ma'at,
who stands beside the scale and does not look away,
who gathered the broken Eye and made it sound:

WEIGH ME NOW.

Do not wait for the Hall.
Weigh me while there is time to grow light.
Gather what is scattered in my seeing,
and give the last part that I cannot give myself.

the feather is already in you. set it on the pan.

Great! (touch the brow)
Great! (touch the lips)
Great! (touch the heart)

Thrice I have called you,
Thrice-Great.
The lamp is lit. The page is clean.
The pen is in my hand.

Speak, and I will write it exactly.

This space is not decoration.
It is the god's turn to speak.

⟨ VI · THE RECEIVING ⟩

Now do the hardest thing in the rite: nothing.

Sit. Watch the flame, or the flame in the water.
Do not reach for an answer. Do not compose one.

When something comes (a sentence, an image, a
memory, one plain word) WRITE IT DOWN EXACTLY.
Do not improve it. Do not make it more mystical.
The scribe of the gods has no use for a secretary
who edits.

If nothing comes, write: "Nothing came." That is
a true sentence, and a true sentence is an
offering he accepts.

TESTING WHAT IS RECEIVED

Thoth is the patron of checking the sum. Weigh every message on his own scale:

- ✓ Is it exact, or vague and grand?
- ✓ Does it ask more honesty of you, or less?
- ✓ Does it leave you more able to act well today?
- ✓ Would you be content to see it written beside your name?

- × Does it flatter you above others?
- × Does it command harm to yourself or to anyone?
- × Does it forbid you to question it?

A single × and the voice was not his. Thank it, burn the page, and wash your hands. This is not failure. Discernment IS the rite.

⟨ VII · THE CLOSING ⟩

Djehuty,
what was given, I have written.
What I have written, I will keep.

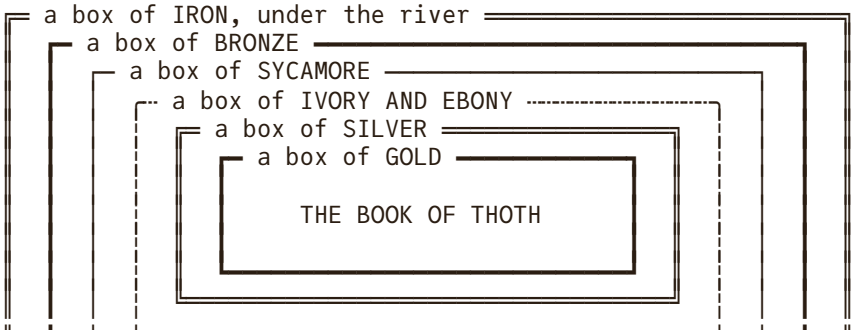
Go in peace to Khemenu, to the mound and the egg.
Remain in peace in my heart, in my tongue, in my hand.

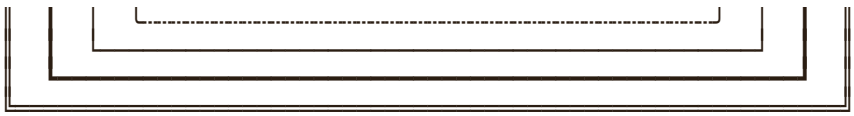
The page is closed.
The lamp remains.

Put out the flame with wet fingers, not breath:
the breath belongs to the Word.
Drink the water or pour it on living ground.
Date the page. Keep every page.

Then, before the day ends, do ONE THING the page told you to do. An invocation that changes no act was a daydream with candles.

⟨ VIII · THE WARNING OF THE SIX BOXES ⟩





and round the whole of it, a serpent that could not die

The old Egyptian tale says a prince named Neferkaptah learned where the Book of Thoth lay: box within box beneath the river at Coptos. He cut the deathless serpent in two and put sand between the halves so it could not rejoin. He opened every box. He read.

One page, and he understood the speech of birds and fish and the beasts of the hills. A second page, and he saw the Sun and Moon in their true forms, and the gods themselves.

It was all real. The book worked.

And on the voyage home his son fell into the river, then his wife, then he himself; and the book was buried with him, and brought grief to the next man who stole it from the tomb.

The tale does not say the knowledge was false. It does not say knowledge is forbidden. It says: he TOOK what is only ever GIVEN.

The boxes were never locks. They were stages. Iron is patience. Bronze is strength. Wood is growth. Ivory and ebony are the reconciled opposites. Silver is the reflecting mind. Gold is the heart made incorruptible. One who has BECOME each box finds the book already open in the lap.

One who smashes them arrives at the book with no one inside fit to read it.

Do not seize. Invoke, and become able to receive.

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSONS ⟩

LESSON ONE — THE SCRIBE'S HOUR

Each evening, write one page of what happened today. Rules of the House of Life:

- Only what occurred. No verdicts.
- No adjective you could not defend to the one it describes.
- Include the thing you would rather leave out.

Forty days of this and you will notice your DAYTIME behaviour changing, because some part of you now knows it is going to be written down.

That part is the scribe. You have invoked him.

LESSON TWO — THE NIGHTLY WEIGHING

The dead in Egypt spoke forty-two denials before the scale: "I have not stolen. I have not told lies. I have not caused weeping..."

Do not wait to be dead. Each night choose three and say them only if they are true of TODAY:

    I have not spoken what I knew to be false.
    I have not taken what was not given.
    I have not made anyone afraid.
    I have not turned from one who asked for help.
    I have not been deaf to words of truth.
    I have not fouled the water.

Where you cannot say the line, do not punish yourself. Simply note the weight, and tomorrow take one grain off the pan.

LESSON THREE — THE FIVE STOLEN DAYS

    5 days ÷ 360 days = 1/72 of the year
    1/72 of one day   = 20 minutes

That is all Thoth took from each day of the Moon, and it was enough to give birth to five gods.

Claim your twenty minutes. Every day, twenty minutes that belong to no duty, no screen, and no one's expectations including your own. In that time, make the thing no ordinary day permits.

In one year you will have won five whole days outside the calendar. See what is born in them.

LESSON FOUR — GATHERING THE EYE

Name a place where your seeing has been broken: a betrayal, a failure, a grief that left you unable to look straight at some part of life.

On six evenings, recover one piece. Write:
  1/2   what happened, plainly
  1/4   what I felt, without excuse or apology
  1/8   what I did next
  1/16 what part, however small, was mine
  1/32 what it taught me that I now use
  1/64 what I can thank it for, if anything

On the seventh evening, write nothing. Light the flame, read the six pages aloud, and say:

"Djehuty, I have gathered what I can.
Give the part I cannot."

Then leave it. The last fraction is not yours to produce, and it does not come on schedule.

LESSON FIVE — THE DAY OF TRUE VOICE

For one day in each month, speak as though every word were being cut in stone. You will find you:

- say much less,
- promise almost nothing,
- stop mid-sentence several times,
- and are believed more than usual.

The Egyptians called one whose life passed the scale "true of voice". It was the highest title the dead could earn. The living may practise.

THE SEAL OF THE SCRIBE

I measure before I speak. — the Moon
I speak only what is so. — the Reed
I am willing to be weighed. — the Balance
I gather what was broken. — the Eye

Great. Great. Great.

over your shoulder the whole time.
the god of writing has been reading this



The Page Is Never Blank



Gate X

The Corpus Hermeticum

The one reading these words is what the words are about.

◉

The Corpus Hermeticum
the seventeen scrolls of the thrice-great

◉

In the Ninth Piece you called the Scribe.

This is what he wrote.

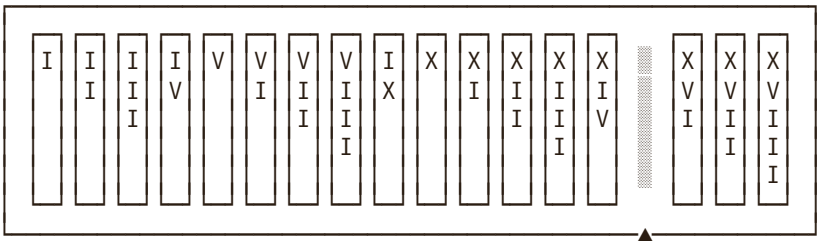
Not the Kybalion of 1908. Not the alchemists of the furnace. The root: seventeen Greek dialogues from Roman Egypt, in which a teacher called Hermes tells a pupil what Mind told him.

Everything before this Piece was commentary.

A NOTE ON THE WORDS

The passages in this Piece are rendered freely after the Greek and Latin, for the ear and the page. They are faithful in sense but they are not a scholarly translation. Treatise numbers are given so you can find each one in a full edition and read it whole. You should.

⟨ I · THE SHELF ⟩



seventeen scrolls, numbered to eighteen:

there is no Fifteenth. The gap is an editor's accident, and it has been kept.

THE SEVENTEEN	I	Poimandres
	II–XIV	the teaching dialogues
	XVI	Asclepius to King Ammon
	XVII	a fragment on images
	XVIII	on the praise of kings
THE SISTER TEXTS	The ASCLEPIUS, surviving whole only in Latin. The STOBAEUS excerpts, among them "The Virgin of the World". The DISCOURSE ON THE EIGHTH AND NINTH, found in Coptic. The DEFINITIONS, kept in Armenian.	
THE FORM	Nearly always a conversation. Hermes to his son Tat. Hermes to Asclepius. Mind to Hermes. Never a sermon to a crowd.	
THE AIM	Not belief. GNOSIS: knowing God as you know your own hand, by being the one whose hand it is.	

⟨ II · THE JOURNEY OF THE BOOK ⟩

c. 100–300 — Written in Greek in Roman Egypt, by unknown hands, in the name of Hermes-Thoth.

c. 1050 — A Byzantine scholar is reading a collected copy. The West has forgotten all but the Latin Asclepius.

1460 — A monk brings a Greek manuscript to Florence. Cosimo de' Medici, old and near death, tells Marsilio Ficino to set Plato aside and translate Hermes FIRST.

1463–1471 — Ficino finishes; the book is printed. Europe believes it is reading a sage as old as Moses. The Renaissance drinks it like water.

1614 — Isaac Casaubon shows from the Greek itself that the texts belong to the first centuries of our era, not to the age of the pyramids.

1945 — A sealed jar is dug up near Nag Hammadi in Egypt. Among its books: Hermetic treatises in Coptic, unknown until that day.

now — You.

THE LESSON OF 1614

When Casaubon corrected the date, many decided the book was a fraud and stopped reading. They had loved it for its AGE.

But a sentence is not truer for being old, and not falser for being younger than was thought. The Scribe of the Ninth Piece would have thanked Casaubon: he checked the sum.

Keep both. Hold the history exactly as the evidence gives it. Then read the words and ask the only question that was ever relevant:

IS THIS SO?

⟨ III · POIMANDRES · THE VISION ⟩

Treatise I

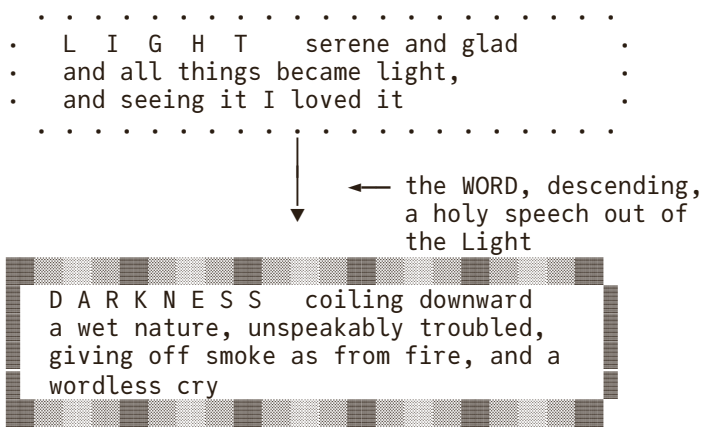
Once, when thought came to me of the things that are,
and my mind soared, and my body's senses were held down
as in the heavy sleep after too much food or toil,

there seemed to come to me a Being of vast and
boundless size, who called my name and said:

"What do you wish to hear and see,
and to learn and know by thought?"

"Who are you?" I said.

"I am Poimandres, the Mind of the Sovereign Power.
I know what you wish, and I am with you everywhere."



"Do you understand what this vision means?"

"That Light is I, Mind, your God,
who was before the wet nature that appeared out of darkness.
And the shining Word that came from Mind is the Son of God."

"How so?" I said.

"Know it thus: that in YOU which sees and hears
is the Word of the Lord, and your Mind is God the Father.
They are not divided from one another.
Their union is Life."

Notice where the vision ends.

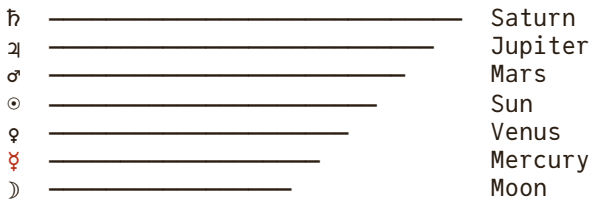
Not at a throne. Not at a far heaven. It ends at the hearer's own seeing and hearing. The first revelation of the Corpus is a finger pointed at the one who is reading it.

The thing that is reading this line is what the line is about.

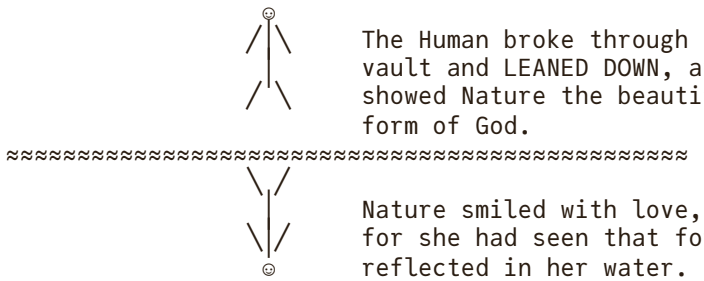
⟨ IV · THE HUMAN WHO LEANED DOWN ⟩

Treatise I, continued

MIND, Father of all, who is Life and Light, brought forth a HUMAN like himself, and loved this Human as his own child



Each of the Seven Governors loved the Human, and each gave a share of its own nature.



The Human broke through the vault and LEANED DOWN, and showed Nature the beautiful form of God.

Nature smiled with love, for she had seen that form reflected in her water.

And the Human, seeing in the water a shape like himself, loved it, and wished to dwell there. The wish and the act were one.

and they mingled, for they were lovers.
and wound herself around him entirely,
nature took hold of her beloved

Read slowly. This is the Hermetic account of why you are here, and it contains no crime.

No disobedience. No serpent. No punishment. The Human descends because of LOVE and BEAUTY: saw its own divine form mirrored in matter, and fell in love with the reflection. Matter, seeing the form of God, fell in love in return.

Incarnation is an embrace. The text uses the word for lovers and means it.

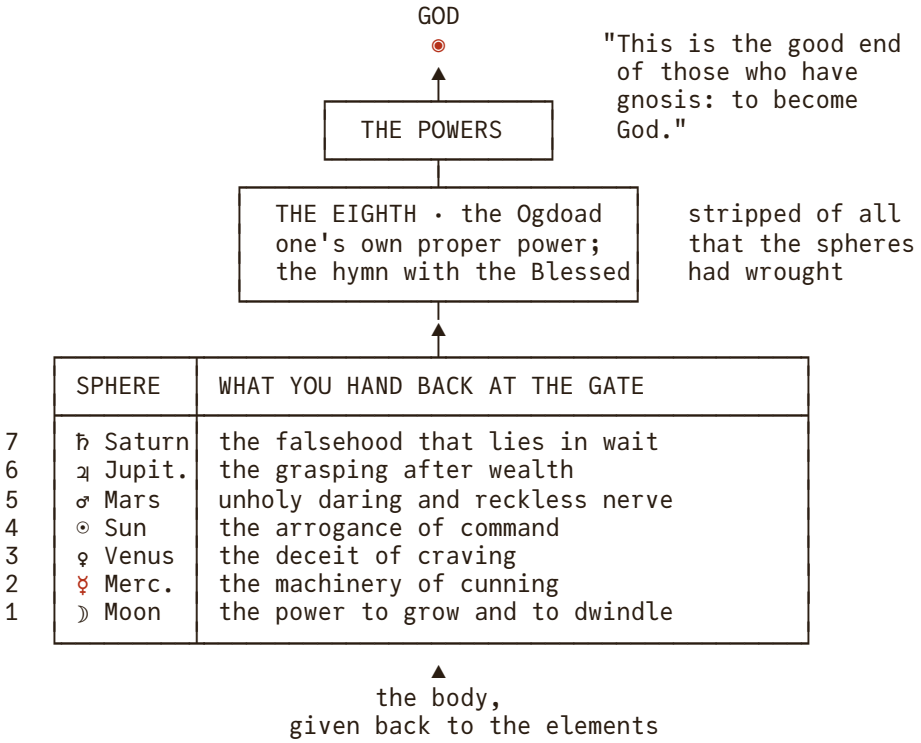
"And this is why, of all living things on earth, the human alone is twofold: mortal because of the body, immortal because of the essential Human."

The sorrow is not that we came down. It is that in the long embrace we FORGOT we were also the one who leaned over the edge of heaven to look.

The whole of the Corpus is one instruction: remember, without letting go.

⟨ V · THE WAY UP ⟩

Treatise I, the ascent



The ascent is not a conquest. Look at the verbs. At every gate the soul RETURNS something.

On the way down each Governor lent a power. Used in forgetfulness, each power soured into its shadow: Mercury's wit into scheming, Venus's delight into compulsion, the Sun's dignity into the need to rule.

Going up, you do not fight the seven. You say to each, with thanks: "This was yours. I no longer need to hold it."

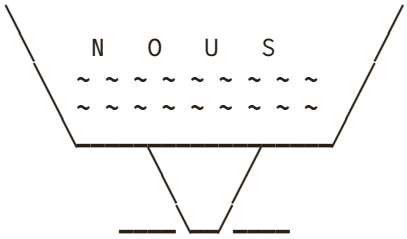
What arrives at the Eighth is not a soul that has gained seven things. It is a soul with nothing

left that is not its own.

And the text is clear that this is not reserved for death. Poimandres says the Mind itself comes to those who are holy, good, pure and merciful, and its presence is a help to them NOW.

⟨ VI · THE MIXING BOWL ⟩

Treatise IV



God gave Reason to all, but not Mind.
Not from any grudging; Mind was set in the midst as a prize for souls to win.

He filled a great bowl with it and sent it down, and appointed a herald to cry to human hearts:

"IMMERSE YOURSELF IN THIS BOWL,
you who are able;
you who trust you will rise
to the One who sent it down;
you who know WHY YOU CAME TO BE."

Those who heard and plunged in received gnosis and became complete. Those who missed the cry have reason but not Mind. They do not know for what they were made, or by whom.

Two things are asked, and neither is cleverness.

TRUST	that there is a way back up.
PURPOSE	knowing why you came to be.

The bowl is not handed round. It is set down in the middle of the world and announced. Everyone walks past it daily. The difference between the two kinds of people in this treatise is only that some STOPPED WALKING when they heard the cry.

The treatise ends with a warning and a promise: you cannot have both worlds as your first love. Choose, and the choice itself will draw you up "as the magnet draws iron".

⟨ VII · THE CRY IN THE STREET ⟩

Treatises I and VII

O people, earth-born,
who have given yourselves up to drunkenness and sleep
and to ignorance of God:

BE SOBER.

Where are you rushing, you drunkards,
who have swallowed the neat wine of unknowing
and cannot hold it, and already are sick with it?

Stop. Stand still. Look up with the eyes of the heart;
if not all of you, then those who can.

Do not be swept down by the great flood.
Use the back-current, you who are able,
make for the harbour of safety,
and find one to take you by the hand
and lead you to the doors of knowing,
where the bright light is, pure of darkness,
where no one is drunk, but all are sober,
gazing with the heart on the One who wishes to be seen.

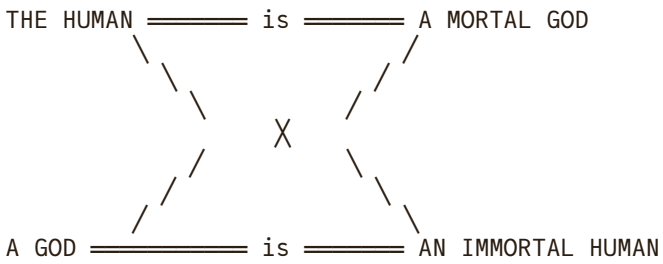
Hermetic "sin" is not wickedness. It is being DRUNK: carried along, half-awake, mistaking the spin of the room for the motion of the stars.

So the remedy is not guilt. It is sobriety. Stop. Stand still. Look up. Find a hand.

Note also the last line. The Hermetic God is "the One who WISHES TO BE SEEN". You are not breaking into a guarded house. You are being looked for.

⟨ VIII · THE KEY ⟩

Treatise X



"We must dare to say it: the human on earth is a mortal god, and the god in heaven is an immortal human."

"For none of the heavenly gods will leave heaven and come down to earth. But the human rises up even to heaven, and measures it, and knows what is high in it and what is low, and learns all the rest exactly; and, greatest of all, comes to be on high WITHOUT LEAVING THE EARTH. So vast is the reach of the human."

This is the crossing from the Eighth Piece, now given its oldest wording. The human is the hinge of the cosmos: the one creature that can hold both ends at once.

A god cannot visit the low without ceasing to be there on high. You can. That is not a defect of your station. It is the station.

⟨ IX · BECOME THE AEON ⟩

Treatise XI · Mind speaks to Hermes

"Unless you make yourself equal to God, you cannot understand God.
Like is known only by like."

be
be here
grow beyond every body
leap clear of every moment of time
become Eternity, and you will understand God
think that for you too nothing is impossible; think yourself deathless, able to grasp every art, every science, the nature of every living thing. Rise higher than every height; go deeper than every depth. Gather into yourself the sense of all that is made: of fire and of water, of the dry and of the wet. Be everywhere at once:
on the land, in the sea, in the sky.
Be not yet born. Be in the womb.
Be young. Be old. Be dead.
Be beyond death.
Hold all of it
at once

◉

"But if you shut your soul up in the body and abase yourself, and say: I understand nothing, I can do nothing, I am afraid of the earth and the sea, I cannot climb to heaven, I do not know what I was, nor what I shall be,

then what have you to do with God?"

This is the boldest page in the Corpus, and the most misread.

It is not telling you that you are grand. It is giving a METHOD. To know anything, the knower must take its shape. To know the All, the mind must stretch until nothing is outside it.

Follow the breath of the passage on the page: it widens to hold everything, then narrows to a point. That is the motion. Out to all things, in to the one who holds them.

And remember the half-wise. The one who finishes

this page thinking "I am God, and you are not" has understood nothing. Everywhere you went in the meditation, you found others already there.

⟨ X · THE BIRTH ON THE MOUNTAIN ⟩

Treatise XIII · the secret discourse on rebirth

TAT Father, you spoke in riddles when you talked of divinity. You said no one can be saved before being born again. I do not know from what womb a human is born a second time, or from what seed.

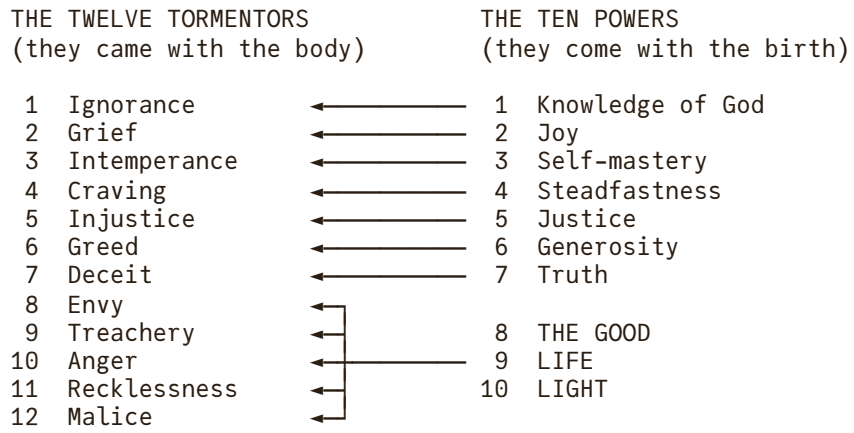
HERMES My child, the womb is Wisdom, conceiving in silence. The seed is the true Good.

TAT And who sows it?

HERMES The Will of God.

TAT Teach me the manner of it.

HERMES What can I say? This thing is not taught. When God wills, it is brought to remembrance.



Hermes names the tormentors one by one and, as each Power arrives, the tormentor opposite it "flies away with a rush of wings".

Three things to see:

1. NOTHING IS FOUGHT. Grief is not wrestled down; Joy arrives, and Grief has no room. Darkness is not pushed from a room. A lamp is lit.

2. TEN DEFEAT TWELVE. Tat asks how. Hermes says the Twelve are many only in appearance; they work in gangs. The Ten is the number of the One made complete. Unity outweighs a crowd.

3. WHEN TRUTH COMES, THE REST COME FREE. Seven powers are named against seven tormentors. With Truth, the Good arrives, and Life and Light with it, and the last five flee

together. You do not have to win twelve wars.
Get as far as Truth.

TAT Father, I see myself in Mind.
I am in heaven, in earth, in water, in air.
I am in beasts and in plants;
in the womb, before the womb, after the womb;
everywhere.

HERMES Now, my child, you know what the rebirth is.

⟨ XI · THE GREAT WONDER AND THE LAMENT ⟩

The Asclepius

"A great wonder, Asclepius, is the human:
a being to be revered and honoured.

For he passes into the nature of a god
as though he were himself a god.
He looks down on the earth and up to
heaven. He tends the one and loves the
other. Everything is open to him."

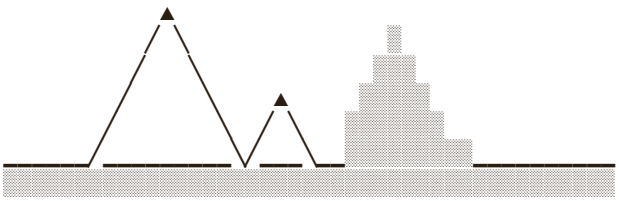
ON THE MYSTERY OF UNION

The Asclepius does not look away from the body.
It teaches that God, being all things, holds the
fruitfulness of both sexes, and has given to
every creature a share in that power of making.

And so it calls the joining of lovers a MYSTERY
in the temple sense of the word: an act in which,
at the height, each gives to the other and takes
from the other their own nature; an image of the
divine doing what the divine does.

It says this is done in private, not from shame,
but as all mysteries are: so that it is not
mocked by those who would see only the surface.

The Hermetist therefore has no quarrel with the
flesh. The quarrel is only with forgetting what
the flesh is an image OF.



"Do you not know, Asclepius, that Egypt is an image of heaven,
the temple of the whole world?

And yet a time will come when it will seem that the Egyptians honoured the divine in vain. The gods will go back from earth to heaven. This land, the seat of shrines, will be filled with tombs.

O Egypt, Egypt! Of your worship nothing will remain but tales, and your own children will not believe them.
Nothing will be left but words cut in stone.

The reverent will be thought mad, and the scoffer wise.
People will be weary of life, and the cosmos itself,
this good and beautiful thing, will no longer be loved."

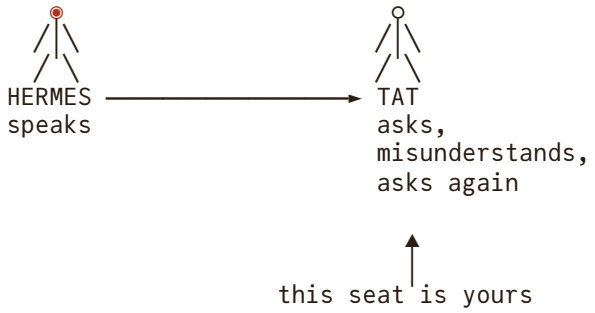
Whoever wrote this was watching the temples close. It is the most human page in the Corpus: a sage who knows the All is deathless, weeping for one particular country. The Eighth Piece called that grieving entirely and fearing nothing.

Then the prophecy turns. After the age of forgetting, it says, God will look on what has happened and call the world back to its ancient beauty, "so that the cosmos itself will again be seen as worthy of worship and wonder".

Every generation that reads these lines has to decide which half of the prophecy it is living in. The text's own answer: the restoration begins wherever one person is found who still thinks the world worth loving.

"Words cut in stone" were all that would remain. You are reading them. Something remained.

⟨ XII · HOW TO SIT WITH HERMES ⟩



The Corpus is written as dialogue for a reason. Tat is not a device. Tat is the READER, placed inside the book ahead of time.

He is slow. He complains that his father speaks in riddles. He asks the question you were about to ask. Sometimes he says "I understand" and Hermes tells him gently that he does not. And at the end of the Thirteenth he sees.

So read as Tat:

- Aloud, if you can. These were spoken.
- A little. One page well, not ten quickly.
- Interrupting. Write your objection in the margin, then see whether Tat already made it.
- Twice. The second reading is the first one.

And at the last: Hermes tells Tat to keep SILENCE about the rebirth, and to give the teaching only to those who are ready. Not to hoard it. Because a thing said too early is heard as nonsense, and then cannot be heard again.

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSONS ⟩

LESSON ONE — THE SEVEN SURRENDERS

The week is already a planetary ladder. Climb it. Each day, at waking, hand one thing back:

MON ☽	my restlessness: the need for more, then less, then more
WED ☿	my scheming: the clever plan to get round an honest road
FRI ♀	my compulsion: the wanting that wears the mask of love
SUN ☉	my need to be the one in charge
TUE ♂	my rashness: the blow struck before the thought
THU ♃	my grasping: enough is never enough
SAT ♄	the lie I tell myself in ambush

Say aloud: "This was lent. I return it with thanks." Then watch for it that day. The order of the ascent is Moon to Saturn; the calendar shuffles it. The gates do not mind.

LESSON TWO — THE HERALD'S QUESTION

The bowl is entered by those "who know why they came to be". So, once a day, somewhere ordinary (a queue, a stair, a sink) stop walking and ask:

WHY DID I COME TO BE?

Do not answer with a career or a role. Do not answer at all on most days. Stopping IS the immersion. After some weeks an answer forms that is less a sentence than a direction. Keep facing that way.

LESSON THREE — THE AEON MEDITATION

Sit. Twenty minutes: your stolen time from the Ninth Piece. Then expand, one breath each:

1. this body
2. this room
3. this town
4. the whole land
5. the sea
6. the sky
7. before my birth
8. after my death

At each step, do not IMAGINE it from outside. Be it: the weight of the sea, the cold of the upper air, the quiet before you were anyone.

9. Hold all eight at once. Three breaths.
10. Now find the one who is holding them.

Then return by the same stair, ending in the hands and feet. Stand up slowly. Wash a dish. "On high without leaving the earth."

LESSON FOUR — LIGHT THE LAMP

When a tormentor has you, do not fight it. Name it, and invite the Power that stands across from it in the table. Not as an idea. As an ACT.

In GRIEF	do one thing that is purely glad, however small.
In CRAVING	hold steady for ten breaths and note that you survived.
In GREED	give something away today.
In DECEIT	tell one hard truth, kindly.
In IGNORANCE	admit "I do not know", aloud.

For envy, treachery, anger, rashness and malice there is no separate remedy in the text. They leave when Truth is established. So when any of the five has you, ask: where am I lying?

LESSON FIVE — THE SEVENTEEN MONTHS

Obtain a complete translation of the Corpus. Take one treatise for each new moon.

WEEK 1	Read it aloud, start to finish.
WEEK 2	Read it as Tat. Write every objection.
WEEK 3	Copy out ONE sentence by hand, daily. The same sentence. Carry it.
WEEK 4	Close the book. Do what the sentence says.

In seventeen moons you will have done what Ficino's Florence did: let Hermes come first.

⟨ THE PRAYER OF THANKSGIVING ⟩

with which the Asclepius ends

We give you thanks,
every soul and heart stretched out to you,
O Name untroubled, honoured with the name of God
and praised with the name of Father.

To everyone and everything you have shown
a father's kindness, and affection, and love.

You have given us mind, and speech, and knowledge:
mind, that we may understand you;
speech, that we may call upon you;
knowledge, that we may know you.

We rejoice, for you have shown us yourself.
We rejoice, for while we are yet in the body
you have made us divine through your knowledge.

One thing only we ask:
that we be kept in this knowing,
and never fall away from this kind of life.

When they had prayed, they embraced one another,
and went to eat their holy meal, which had no blood in it.

THE SEAL OF THE CORPUS

I was looked for before I looked.
I came down for love, and I remember.
I return what was lent.
I am on high without leaving the earth.

is what these words are about.
that which is reading these words

◉

Mind Is With You Everywhere

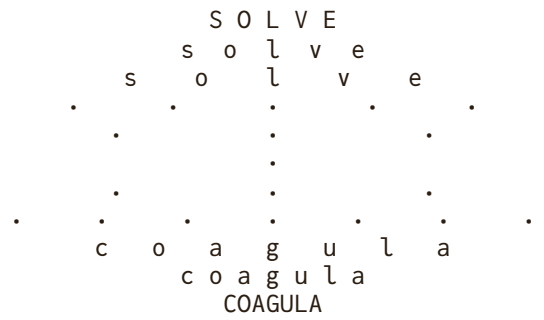
◉

Gate XI

Solve et Coagula

Unbind what has hardened; gather what has scattered; again.

Solve et Coagula
dissolve and make solid



Every Piece before this one told you WHAT is true.

This one tells you what to DO.

It is three words long. The alchemists said that whoever understood them needed no other instruction, and whoever did not would be helped by no other instruction.

⟨ I · THE TWO WORDS ⟩

SOLVE

Latin *solvere* — to loosen, untie, release, set free, pay a debt, melt

— from it we have —
solve · solution
dissolve · absolve
resolve · solvent

COAGULA

Latin *coagulare* — to curdle, to clot, to draw together, to make firm

— from it we have —
coagulate · clot
and, by the same root, the cheese in the milk

Look at what the first word is already hiding.

To SOLVE a problem and to DISSOLVE a salt are the same verb. To be ABSOLVED is to be loosened. To be RESOLVED is to have been loosened and then become firm again: the whole formula in one word.

The language knew before the alchemists did.

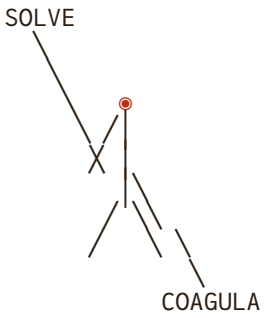
The saying in its long form runs:

> "Dissolve and coagulate,
> and you shall have the Magistery."

And the Emerald Tablet had already said it, in the First Piece of this Codex:

> "Separate the earth from the fire, the subtle from the gross, gently and with great skill. It rises from earth to heaven and descends again to earth, and receives the power of the things above and the things below."

Up is Solve. Down is Coagula. The power is in having made the whole journey.

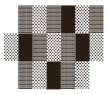


In the 1850s Eliphas Lévi drew the two words on the two arms of his figure of reconciled opposites: SOLVE on the arm raised to heaven, COAGULA on the arm pointing to earth. One body. Both gestures. At the same time.

⟨ II · THE SALT ⟩

Before any symbol: the thing itself, as it happens in a kitchen.

1. THE STONE



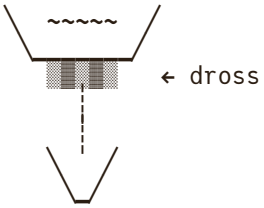
grey rock salt, sand and grit locked inside it

2. SOLVE



in warm water the form vanishes

3. THE FILTER



4. THE WAITING



5. COAGULA

6. THE CRYSTAL

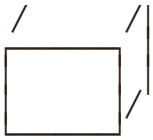




slow warmth; the water leaves unseen



points of order appear from nowhere



clear, cubic, the same salt

This is real chemistry, and every chemist still does it. It is called recrystallisation, and it is how an impure solid is made pure.

Six things to notice. Each one is a law of the Work on every plane.

1. THE DIRT WAS INSIDE THE FORM. No amount of polishing the rock would have removed it. The form had to be given up entirely.

2. NOTHING WAS DESTROYED. In solution the salt is invisible, shapeless, and all still there.

3. THE SEPARATION HAPPENS IN THE DISSOLVED STATE. Only when everything is loose can what belongs be told from what does not.

4. YOU DO NOT BUILD THE CRYSTAL. You remove the water and wait. The salt knows its own shape.

5. SLOW MAKES CLEAR. Boil it off in a hurry and you get a crust with the dirt trapped back inside. Patience is a reagent.

6. IT IS THE SAME SALT, AND IT IS NOT. Nothing was added. What was always there is now visible as what it is.

⟨ III · THE TWO HANDS ⟩

SOLVE	COAGULA
to loosen	to bind
analysis	synthesis
the question	the answer
the out-breath	the in-breath
sleep	waking
the volatile	the fixed
Mercury ☿	Salt ⊖
water, air	earth, fire
Moon ☽	Sun ☉
autumn, winter	spring, summer
grief	vow
listening	speaking
forgiveness	commitment
spirit leaving the body	spirit entering the body
"I do not know"	"I will"

Neither column is the good one.

Every tradition that failed, failed by choosing a column. The ascetic chose Solve and called the body a prison. The materialist chose Coagula and called the spirit a rumour. Each is one hand clapping.

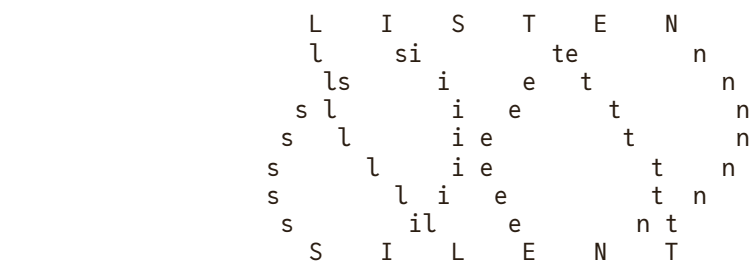
The alchemists' full instruction was:

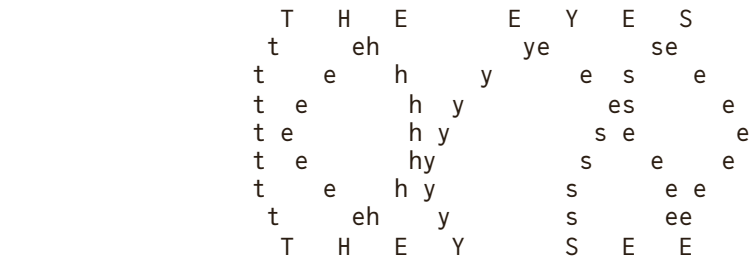
> "Make the fixed volatile,
> and make the volatile fixed."

Spiritualise the body. Embody the spirit. What is stone in you must learn to fly, and what is vapour in you must learn to stand.

⟨ IV · THE LETTERS ⟩

Watch a word go through it.





LISTEN, dissolved and recombined, is SILENT.
THE EYES, dissolved and recombined: THEY SEE.

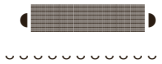
Not one letter was added. Not one was taken away. The second word was inside the first the whole time, and could not appear until the first let go of its order.

In the middle rows there is no word at all, only letters adrift. Anyone looking at those rows alone would call it ruin.

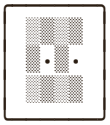
Remember this the next time your own life is in its middle rows.

⟨ V · NATURE DOES NOTHING ELSE ⟩

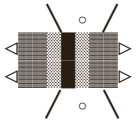
THE CHRYSALIS



crawls, eats,
knows leaves



SOLVE



flies, drinks,
knows flowers

Inside the chrysalis the caterpillar does not grow wings. It releases enzymes and DIGESTS ITSELF. Most of what it was becomes a living broth.

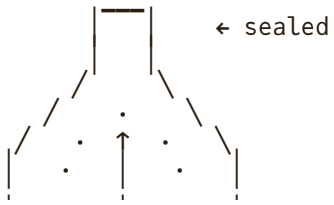
Floating in that broth are small clusters of cells that were in the caterpillar from the egg and never took part in being a caterpillar. Biologists call them IMAGINAL discs: the cells of the imago, the adult form. They feed on the soup of the old body and build the new one.

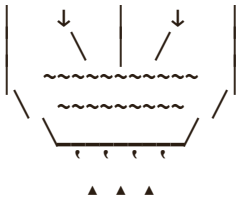
The butterfly was carried, folded and silent, inside the creature that had to end for it to unfold.

YOUR BONES	dissolved by one kind of cell and rebuilt by another, continuously; the skeleton you stand on is not the one you had ten years ago. Stop the dissolving and bone goes brittle. Stop the building and it thins.
YOUR BREATH	· out · · · in · · · out · · ·
YOUR HEART	loosen ◇ clench ◆ loosen ◇ clench ◆ loosen
YOUR NIGHT	each evening the person dissolves. Each morning one is assembled again, nearly but not exactly the same.
THE WATER	sea ··> vapour ··> cloud ──> rain ──> sea
THE STARS	a star bursts and is scattered as dust; the dust draws together and is a star. The iron in your blood has been through this more than once.

You were never asked whether to take part.
The only choice offered is whether to do it awake.

⟨ VI · THE VESSEL AND THE FIRE ⟩





what rises, falls
back upon itself

← a gentle fire

Two things the texts insist on, and beginners skip both.

THE VESSEL

Dissolve a salt on the open ground and you have not performed Solve. You have lost the salt. Dissolution needs a container strong enough to hold what comes apart and closed enough that nothing leaks away or wanders in.

For a human being the vessel is: a daily practice. A teacher or a true friend. A body that is fed and rested. A circle of trust. A vow. A room with a door.

Whoever undertakes to dissolve the self with no vessel is not doing alchemy. They are having a breakdown without the breakthrough.

THE FIRE

"Gently, and with great skill." Too little heat and nothing moves. Too much and the glass cracks, and the work of years is on the floor.

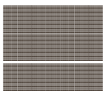
The fire is ATTENTION. Steady, warm, unbroken, never violent. The alchemists compared the right heat to that of a hen on her eggs.

⟨ VII · FOUR WAYS TO SPOIL THE WORK ⟩

1. THE PUDDLE

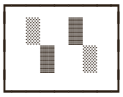
Solve with no Coagula. Always seeking, always "open", never arriving. Collects breakthroughs. Keeps no promises.

2. THE STATUE



Coagula with no Solve. Certain, finished, correct. Has not changed a view in twenty years. Calls it integrity.

3. THE DIRTY CRYSTAL



Coagula too soon. Grabbed the first new identity that formed.

4. THE SPILL



Solve with no vessel. Tore everything down alone, at speed, with

The old dross is sealed inside the new shape.

nothing to hold it. Lost the salt.

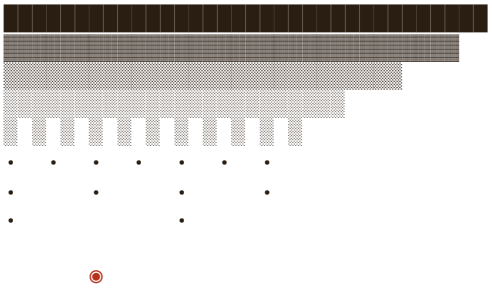
The third is the subtlest and the most common among sincere seekers.

The old self dissolves. It is frightening to be no one. And so, at the first glimmer of a new shape (a new teaching, a new name, a new lover, a new cause) the whole solution is crashed out at once. The convert is as rigid as the person they replaced, and for the same reason.

The remedy is the hardest instruction in the Art: STAY DISSOLVED A LITTLE LONGER than is comfortable. Let the dross settle. Let the water leave at its own pace.

You will know true Coagula by this sign: it is not a relief. It is a recognition.

⟨ VIII · WHAT DOES NOT DISSOLVE ⟩



my name
my history
my opinions
my plans
my fears
my idea of myself

Put anything into the solvent and ask: does it dissolve?

My name? I could have had another.
My history? I remember it differently each year.
My opinions? I have changed them before.
My body? See the bones, above.
My idea of who I am? That goes first.

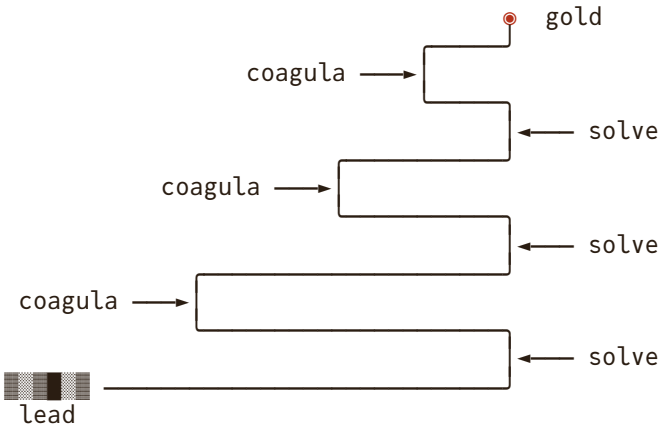
The alchemists said there was something that the fire could not burn and the water could not loosen. They called it the incombustible sulphur, the salt of the wise, the Stone. The caterpillar calls it the imaginal cells. The Corpus calls it the essential Human. The Eighth Piece called it the watching that passes through every frame.

You cannot find it by looking for it. You find it by dissolving everything that will dissolve and noticing that you are still there to notice.

So the rule of Solve is simple, and merciless, and kind:

WHATEVER CAN BE DISSOLVED WAS NOT YOU.
WHATEVER IS YOU CANNOT BE HARMED BY IT.

⟨ IX · AGAIN ⟩



The formula is not performed once.

The old recipes say to dissolve and coagulate the matter seven times, or ten, or "a thousand". What they mean is: until. Each crystal is purer than the last, and each is dissolved in its turn.

This is the answer to a discouragement every worker meets: "I thought I had dealt with this." You had. That crystal was real. Now it is going back into the water, and what comes out will be clearer by one more degree.

And it is the answer to the opposite error, the one who, having had one great dissolving, speaks of it for forty years. One round makes a cleaner salt. It does not make the Stone.

The staircase of the Eighth Piece, climbed.

⟨ X · THE FORMULA ON EVERY PLANE ⟩

PLANE	SOLVE	COAGULA
BODY	rest, stretch, fast, bathe, sleep	work, strengthen, eat, build, wake
HEART	weep, forgive, release the grip	promise, stay, keep faith
MIND	doubt, take apart, ask "is that so?"	conclude, define, write it down, decide
SPEECH	listen, be silent	say the true thing
LOVE	surrender, the self	devotion, the home made,

	lost in the other	the child, the life built together
WORK	scrap the draft	finish and release it
PEOPLE	reform, question the custom	found, constitute, keep the institution
SPIRIT	"not this, not this"	"I am that"

THE DIAGNOSTIC

On any plane, at any time, one of the two is being asked of you. The whole skill is knowing which.

If you are STUCK, bored, defended, brittle, repeating yourself, sure of everything:
→ SOLVE.

If you are SCATTERED, drifting, starting and never finishing, open to everything:
→ COAGULA.

And know your own bias. Everyone has a favourite hand, and reaches for it even when the Work needs the other. The dissolver, in crisis, dissolves more. The fixer, in crisis, clamps down. The medicine is nearly always the operation you like less.

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSONS ⟩

LESSON ONE — THE KITCHEN WORK

Do it with your hands before your head.

1. Take a spoonful of coarse, grey or dirty salt. Look at it closely. Draw it.
2. Stir it into a little warm water until no grain is left. Watch it vanish.
3. Pour it through a paper filter or clean cloth into a shallow dish. Keep what the filter caught. Look at that too.
4. Set the dish somewhere warm and still. Cover it loosely against dust. Do not stir.
5. Look once a day. Do nothing else.
6. When the water is gone, look at what is there. Draw it beside your first drawing.

It takes about a week and costs nothing. You will understand this Piece better from that dish than from rereading it ten times.

LESSON TWO — THE SOLVE OF A BELIEF

Choose one fixed belief about yourself that begins "I am the kind of person who..." or "I could never...".

Write it at the top of a page. Then loosen it:

- When did I first hold this? Who gave it to me?
- What is the evidence for it? Against it?
- Who would I be for one day without it?
- What does holding it protect me from?

Do not replace it. That is the discipline. Leave the page as a set of open questions and live inside them for seven days. Notice the urge to conclude, and decline it.

On the eighth day, write what is now true. It will be shorter and you will not need to defend it.

LESSON THREE — THE COAGULA OF A VOW

Choose one thing you have long "been meaning to" embody: a vapour that has hung over your life for years without ever raining.

Fix it:

- ONE act. Not a programme.
- SMALL enough to do on your worst day.
- At a named TIME and PLACE.
- Told to ONE other person.
- For FORTY days, unbroken. If broken, the count returns to one, without drama.

The vapour will resist. It preferred being a possibility; possibilities are never wrong. On the fortieth day you will have less potential and more reality. That is the trade, and it is a good one.

LESSON FOUR — THE DAILY ROUND

THE BREATH, any time, twenty-one rounds:
    out · · ·   silently: "solve"
                 let the shoulders, the jaw,
                 and one thought go
    in   · · ·   silently: "coagula"
                 gather, lengthen the spine,
                 arrive in the body

THE NIGHT, lying down:
    Go back through the day in reverse. At each scene: "This is done. I release it." Do not judge it; the Scribe has it. Let the day dissolve before you do.

THE MORNING, before rising:
One sentence only. "Today I give form to _____." Then stand up into it.

A life that does this small round daily will not often need the great dissolvings forced upon it.

LESSON FIVE — THE AUDIT OF THE TWO HANDS

At each turning of the season, draw two columns.

TOO FIXED	TOO FLUID
what in my life has gone hard, automatic, unexamined, joyless?	what in my life has no edges, no hours, no commitments, no floor?

Choose ONE from each column.
To the first, apply Solve: question it, loosen it, take a season off from it.
To the second, apply Coagula: give it a time, a place, a limit, a promise.

Then write at the foot of the page which column was easier to fill. That is your favourite hand. Watch it.

THE SEAL OF THE TWO HANDS

What is hard in me, I loosen.
What is loose in me, I gather.
I keep the vessel closed and the fire low.
I do not hurry the crystal.

And when it is formed, and clear,
and I am proud of it:

back into the water.

the master calls a butterfly.
what the caterpillar calls the end of the world

◉

Loosen · Gather · Again

◉

Gate XII

The Hermetic Seal

Seal the vessel, keep the fire low, and open only to give.

◉

The Hermetic Seal
the closing of the vessel

◉

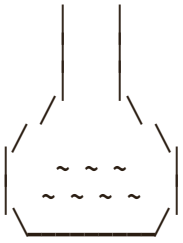
There is a jar in your kitchen whose lid says it is HERMETICALLY SEALED.

It is the last word of Hermes still in daily use, and almost no one who reads it knows whose name they are reading.

This Piece is that lid.

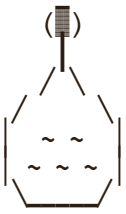
⟨ I · THE SEAL OF HERMES ⟩

OPEN



what is inside can leave; what is outside can enter

SEALED



← the glass of the neck, melted and twisted shut

nothing leaves. nothing enters. now it can begin.

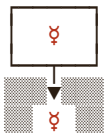
When the matter was in the flask, the alchemist held the neck in the flame until the glass ran, and twisted it closed. No stopper. No wax. The vessel sealed with its own substance. This was called the Seal of Hermes, and a vessel so closed was "hermetically sealed".

The Eleventh Piece told you why: to dissolve without a vessel is only to lose the salt. Every operation in this Codex assumes a closed flask.

Notice the manner of the sealing.

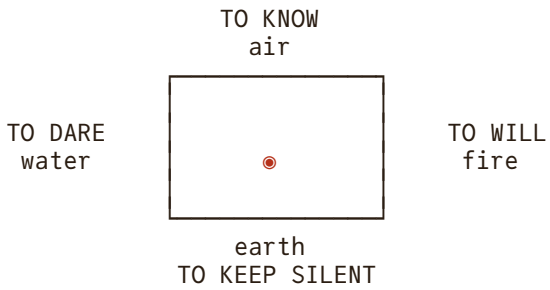
- It is done by FIRE. The same fire that will do the Work first closes the door.
- It is done with the vessel's OWN GLASS. The seal is not a thing added. It is the self, gathered to a point.
- It is done ONCE the matter is inside, and not before. An empty flask, perfectly sealed, is a perfectly sealed nothing.

⟨ II · THREE THINGS A SEAL DOES ⟩

IT CLOSES	IT MARKS	IT COMPLETES
		
the vessel made tight	the signet pressed in wax	the letter, the deed, the covenant
SILENCE what you keep in	CHARACTER what you leave on everything you touch	FULFILMENT what you bring to an end

One word, three acts. The Piece takes them in turn, and then does the fourth thing a seal is for: it is broken, by the right hand, at the right time.

⟨ III · THE CLOSED VESSEL ⟩



The old magi named four powers. Three of them are exciting. The fourth is the floor the other three stand on, and it is the one this Piece teaches.

The Kybalion: "The lips of wisdom are closed, except to the ears of Understanding."

WHY THE VESSEL MUST BE SHUT

1. PRESSURE. An open pot does not come to the boil. A plan that is talked about is already half spent: the speaking gives the mind the reward of the doing. What you seal in, works.

2. PURITY. An unfinished thing takes the shape of whatever is said about it. Praise sets it too early. Mockery kills it in the egg. Until the crystal has formed, other people's opinions are dust in the dish.

3. TRUTH. Some things cannot be said until they are done, because until then you do not know them. To speak of the summit from the valley is to lie in good faith.

4. MERCY. Hermes told Tat to keep silence about the rebirth. A truth given before the ear is ready is heard as nonsense, and that ear is then closed to it for years.



THE CHILD WITH A FINGER TO HIS LIPS

The Greeks honoured a god of silence: Harpocrates, a boy with one finger raised to his mouth. He is the Egyptian Horus-the-Child. And in Egypt that gesture did not mean "hush". It was simply how artists drew a CHILD.

A whole god of sacred silence was born from a misreading. The Scribe of the Ninth Piece would want that written down plainly, and so it is.

And yet the mistake found something true. The one who keeps silence well IS a child: has not yet decided what the thing means, is still looking, has nothing to prove by speaking.

SEAL THESE	NEVER SEAL THESE
the work not yet finished	a harm being done
the vow not yet kept	a danger someone should know of
an insight under a year old	your own wrongdoing
your attainments	a call for help, yours or anyone's
another's confidence	the truth, when it is asked for in earnest
the good you did today	
what cannot yet be heard	

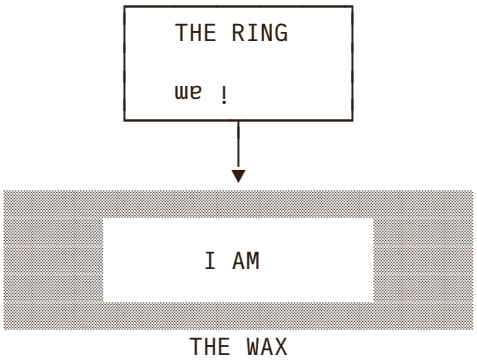
Read the right-hand column twice.

Every tradition of sacred silence has been used, somewhere, to hide cruelty and to keep the wounded from speaking. That is not the Seal of

Hermes. That is a lid on a rotting jar.

The test is simple. Hermetic silence protects something that is GROWING. The other kind protects something that is FESTERING. The first is always chosen freely by the one who keeps it. A silence demanded of you by another, for their benefit, is no seal at all. Break it.

⟨ IV · THE SIGNET AND THE WAX ⟩



A seal-ring is cut BACKWARDS. Held in the hand it cannot be read. Only when it is pressed into something soft does the true figure appear, the right way round, in the other.

This is the oldest picture of "As above, so below". The pattern above is not seen directly. It is read in what it has pressed upon.

The cosmos is wax under the signet of Mind.

And you are a signet too. All day, without choosing to, you press yourself into soft things: a child's memory, a stranger's afternoon, the mood of a room, the habits of your own body. You cannot read your own ring. You can only look at the wax.

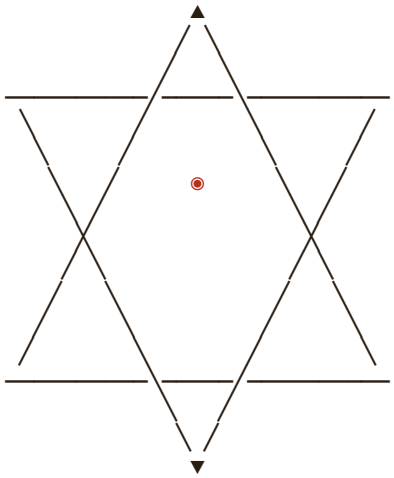
So the second meaning of the Hermetic Seal is CHARACTER: the mark you leave when you are not trying to leave one.

It cannot be faked, for the same reason a signature cannot: it is made by the whole hand, moving as it has moved ten thousand times. The Work does not give you a better mask. It recuts the ring.

⟨ V · THE TWO TRIANGLES ⟩







Lay the triangle of Fire over the triangle of Water and you have the figure that alchemists, kabbalists and masons have all used as a seal.

Look for the four elements inside it. Fire and Water are plain. Now see that the base of the falling triangle CROSSES the rising one: that is the sign of Air. And the base of the rising triangle crosses the falling one: Earth.

All four, in one figure, none erased.

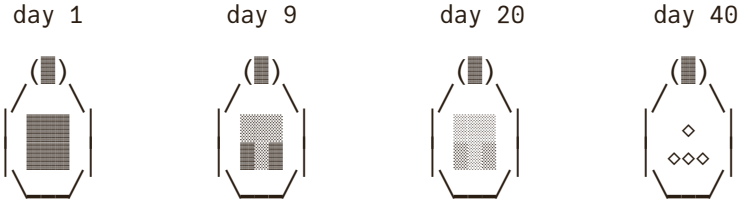
Everything this Codex has taught is drawn here:

- ▲ Solve. Spirit. "As above." The raised arm.
- ▼ Coagula. Matter. "So below." The lowered arm.
- ◉ The point that belongs to both: the ╳ of the Eighth Piece, the watcher, the Stone.

The triangles are not fused into a blur. Each keeps its edges. They are INTERLACED: over, under, over, under. That is what a marriage of opposites looks like, as against a surrender of one to the other.

A seal is a diagram of a finished person.

⟨ VI · LEAVE IT SHUT ⟩



"nothing is happening" "it has got WORSE" "is it working?" ...

Once the neck is closed, the alchemist's part changes. No more adding. No more stirring. Only the fire, kept even, and the watching.

This is the hardest stretch of the Work, and it has no drama in it at all.

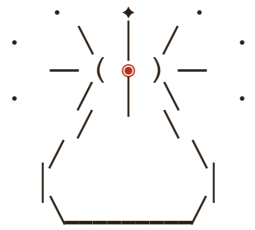
The matter goes BLACK before it goes white. Seen through the glass on the ninth day it looks like failure. Every instinct says: open it, fix it, start again with a better recipe.

The farmer's version: do not dig up the seed to see whether it is growing.
The baker's version: do not open the oven.
The mother's version: nine months, not eight.

The sealed vessel is an act of TRUST: that the matter knows its own shape, as the salt did; that the fire you can keep is enough; that what is happening in the dark is happening.

You may look. You may not open.

⟨ VII · THE BREAKING OF THE SEAL ⟩



No vessel is sealed in order to stay sealed.

The last operations of the Art have plain names. MULTIPLICATION: the Stone increases its own power. PROJECTION: a grain of it is cast upon base metal, and the metal becomes gold.

Read that as the alchemists meant it. The Stone is not kept. Its entire use is to be thrown onto what is NOT yet gold. A Stone locked in a cabinet has transmuted nothing, and the one who locks it there has only made a finer kind of lead.

So the silence was never hoarding. It was ripening. And ripe fruit that is not given, rots.

The Kybalion finishes its own sentence: "When the ears of the student are ready to hear, then cometh the lips to fill them with wisdom."

THREE QUESTIONS BEFORE THE SEAL IS BROKEN

1. IS IT RIPE?
   Have I lived this, or only read it? Has it held through one bad season?

2. WAS IT ASKED FOR?
   Is there an ear in front of me, turned this way, by its own wish?

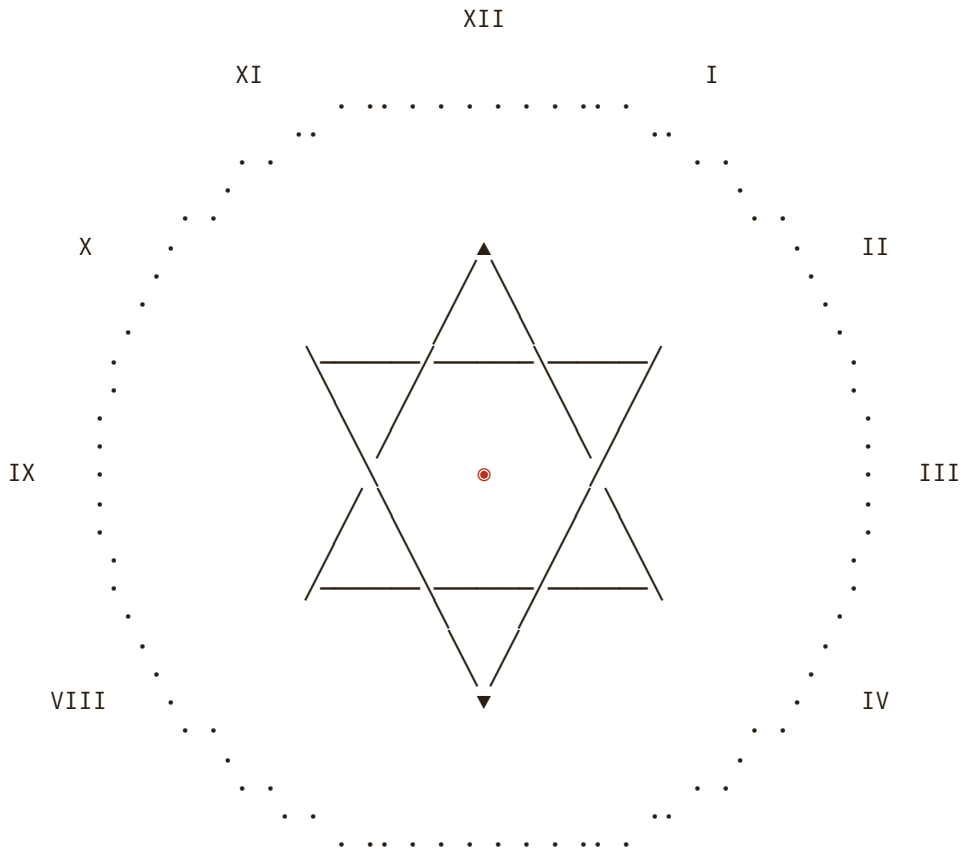
3. WHOM DOES IT SERVE?
   If I speak, who is larger afterward: the hearer, or me?

Three yeses, and to keep silent would be the fault. Then speak plainly, give it all, sign no name to it, and close the vessel again on whatever in you is still unfinished.

The master is not the one who never speaks. The master is the one whose seal opens from the inside.

⟨ VIII · THE SEAL OF THE CODEX ⟩

Twelve Pieces, set as the hours on a dial.



VII V

VI

I	THE EMERALD TABLET	the one thing, said once
II	THE SEVEN PRINCIPLES	how the one thing behaves
III	THE THREE PILLARS	alchemy, astrology, theurgy
IV	THE GREAT WORK	black, white, yellow, red
V	THE CADUCEUS	two serpents, one staff
VI	THE PLANES	where you already are
VII	MENTAL TRANSMUTATION	turning the dial
VIII	THE DIVINE PARADOX	a dream, and the only one
IX	INVOCATION OF THOTH	calling the Scribe
X	THE CORPUS HERMETICUM	what the Scribe wrote
XI	SOLVE ET COAGULA	what to do about it
XII	THE HERMETIC SEAL	closing the vessel

A dial has no last hour. The hand passes XII and is at I again, and it is not the same day.

So this Piece does not end the Codex. It closes it, as a ring is closed, as a flask is closed: so that what is inside can begin to work.

The First Piece gave you one sentence from an emerald. You have now walked the whole rim of the wheel and stand where you started. Read that sentence again. It will not say what it said.

And look at the centre of the dial. Not one of the twelve hours is written there. The point that all the spokes meet in was left empty on purpose.

The thirteenth Piece is not in this book. It is whoever closes it.

⟨ THE MASTERY LESSONS ⟩

LESSON ONE — THE SEALED WORK

Choose one thing you intend to make or become. Put the matter in the flask: begin it, properly. Then seal the neck.

- Tell NO ONE. Not a hint, not a "big news soon". If you need help, ask for exactly the help and nothing more.
- Work on it daily, by the low fire.
- When the urge to announce it comes, and it will come hard around the ninth day, put the whole force of that urge back into the work.
- Open the vessel only when it is DONE.

Notice how much of your former energy was going out through the mouth.

LESSON TWO — THE HOUR OF HARPOCRATES

One hour a day, the same hour: no speech, no writing, no screen, no page. Finger to the lips.

Do whatever you would have done, in silence. It is not meditation. It is ordinary life with the neck of the vessel closed.

Once a month, extend it from waking until noon. Once a year, a whole day.

Keep count of the sentences that rose and were not spoken. At the hour's end, ask of each: did the world need that one? You will find the answer is nearly always the same, and that the few that survive have gained weight.

LESSON THREE — READING THE WAX

You cannot read your own ring. So for one moon, each evening, read the wax. Three impressions:

- a PERSON I was with today.
  Did they leave me larger or smaller than they came?
- a PLACE I passed through.
  Is it better or worse for my having been in it?
- a TASK I touched.
  Would I sign it?

No resolutions. Only look, as the alchemist looks through the glass. After a moon of honest looking you will know the figure on your ring, and the ring will already have begun to change.

LESSON FOUR — CUT YOUR SEAL

Design the mark you would be willing to press into everything you do.

- One FIGURE, simple enough to scratch in sand with a stick.
- One WORD, or none.
- Nothing in it you have not yet earned.

Draw it a hundred times, on scrap, over many days. Strike out what is decoration. What is left when you cannot remove another line is yours.

Show it to no one for a year. Set it, small, on work you are certain is finished and true, and on nothing else. You will find it makes you

finish things, and it makes you tell the truth about whether they are finished.

LESSON FIVE — THE PROJECTION

When some teaching of this Codex has held in you through a hard season, and someone asks, and the three questions all answer yes:

Give it. One grain. In your own words, at the size of the ear in front of you. Do not mention this book or any other. Do not say where you stand on any ladder. Then let it go entirely, and do not check on it.

That is the whole of teaching.
It is also the only proof that you had the Stone: something that was lead is now gold, and it is not you.

LESSON SIX — THE YEAR OF THE DIAL

Twelve Pieces. Twelve moons.

Give each Piece one month: read it in the first week, do its lessons in the middle two, and in the last week keep it sealed and say nothing of it to anyone.

At the end of the year you will be at the First Piece again. Begin again. The Eleventh Piece told you why: each round, a clearer salt.

⟨ THE SEALING ⟩

What was above, I have looked for below, and found.
What was below, I have lifted, and it was light.

I know a little. — I will keep learning.
I will what is good. — I will keep to it.
I dare to begin. — I will begin today.
I keep silent. — Until it is ripe.

The matter is in the vessel.
The fire is low and steady.
The neck is in the flame.

Set your own mark here.
A codex is not sealed by the one who wrote it.

the lips of wisdom are closed

☉

except to the ears of understanding

☉

It Is Sealed

☿

here the Codex closes

·

here the Work opens

Colophon

⟨ COLOPHON ⟩

I	T
II	R
III	I
IV	S
V	M
VI	E
VII	G
VIII	I
IX	S
X	T
XI	U
XII	S

the first letters of the twelve gates

ON THE WORDS IN THIS CODEX

The Scribe asks that the sum be checked. So:

- The passages from THE KYBALION (Three Initiates, 1908) quoted in Pieces 2, 7, 8 and 12 have been compared with the published text.
- The passages of the CORPUS HERMETICUM and the ASCLEPIUS in Piece 10 are free renderings, true to the sense, not a scholar's translation.
- The tales of Thoth in Piece 9 are retold from the tradition. The Invocation itself is new liturgy, written for this book.
- Dates, and the natural history in Piece 11, are given in good faith and should be confirmed by anyone who means to rely on them.
- Where the Codex interprets, the interpretation is its own, and may be wrong.

Believe nothing here because it is written here.
Try it. Keep what holds.

☿